
Counted But Not Centered: Demographic Diversity and Framing in Post-2020 Music Theory Textbooks

Data Report of Research Findings

Overview

Philip Ewell's critiques of music theory's "white racial frame" (2019, 2020, 2023) intensified scrutiny of whose music appears in the discipline's core pedagogical texts. This report asks what has changed since, presenting the full quantitative findings behind a two-part study of composer representation across ten widely used music theory textbooks (twenty editions, 2008–2026). Its guiding distinction is between *counting* composers and *centering* them: a textbook can diversify its roster of names while leaving the analytical core, and the assumptions embedded in it, essentially untouched.

Part One (Repertoire Survey) catalogues every musical example across all twenty editions and records demographic metadata – birth and death dates, gender, birthplace, and racial identity – for each cited composer. To gauge not just how many composers appear but how equitably examples are distributed among them, I apply Pielou Evenness (J'), a metric adapted from biodiversity studies that jointly reflects richness and evenness. I also track the share of examples drawn from the "BHMB" quartet – Bach, Haydn, Mozart, and Beethoven (London 2022) that foregrounds the persistence of a small, male-dominated canon. Editions published after 2020 show real demographic gains: more composers overall, higher female and BIPOC representation, broader geographic range, and a markedly reduced reliance on the BHMB quartet.

Part Two (NLP Framing Analysis) moves from presence to function. Using a passage-level natural language processing pipeline, it classifies *how* each of 5,242 composer mentions is deployed – as a normative, additive, exceptional, or corrective exemplar, or as none of these – and records *where* in each text, and alongside which concepts, those mentions fall. The framing differences are statistically reliable but modest in magnitude: marginalized composers are somewhat more likely than dominant ones to be cast as additive exemplars and less likely to be cast as normative ones. The structural signals are sharper. Marginalized composers cluster in supplementary passages rather than central expository ones, are nearly absent from the application and exercise material through which students actually practice, and are introduced disproportionately alongside rudiments and jazz rather than the voice leading and counterpoint that constitute the analytic core. This subordination operates at several levels at once – quantity, placement, framing language, and associated vocabulary – and persists even in the most recently revised editions and in the volumes with the highest raw diversity counts.

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Textbooks Analyzed

Author(s)	Title	Editions Analyzed
Aldwell, Schachter, & Cadwallader	<i>Harmony and Voice Leading</i>	4th (2011) & 5th (2019)
Benward & Saker	<i>Music in Theory and Practice, Volume 1</i>	8th (2008) & 10th (2021)
Burstein & Straus	<i>Concise Introduction to Tonal Harmony</i>	2nd (2020) & 3rd (2024)
Clendinning & Marvin	<i>The Musician’s Guide to Theory and Analysis</i>	3rd (2016), 4th (2021), & 5th (2026)
Gotham et al.★	<i>Open Music Theory</i>	1st (2023)
Hutchinson★	<i>Music Theory for the 21st-Century Classroom</i>	1st (2024)
Kostka, Payne, & Almén†	<i>Tonal Harmony</i>	7th (2013), 8th (2018), & 9th (2024)
Laitz & Callahan‡	<i>The Complete Musician</i>	2nd (2008), 3rd (2012), 4th (2016), & 5th (2023)
Mount★	<i>Fundamentals, Function, and Form</i>	1st (2020)
Roig-Francolí	<i>Harmony in Context</i>	3rd (2020)

N = 10 textbooks, 20 editions total. Part One (Repertoire Survey) draws on all 20 editions; Part Two (NLP Framing Analysis) covers the most recent edition of all 10 textbooks. ★ Previous studies only looked at 7 books: Aldwell, Benward, Burstein, Clendinning, Kostka, Laitz, Roig-Francolí.
† Dorothy Payne is credited as co-author through the 8th edition; the 9th edition (2024) is credited to Kostka & Almén only.
‡ Michael Callahan joined as co-author with the 5th edition (2023); the 2nd–4th editions are credited to Laitz alone.

Part One: Repertoire Survey

Demographic and geographic analysis of composer representation across 10 core textbooks.

In many of the following plots, a vertical dashed line marks the year 2020 indicating the dividing line of the pre- and post-Ewell epochs.

i. Racial Representation

1.1. Share of Musical Examples by Race

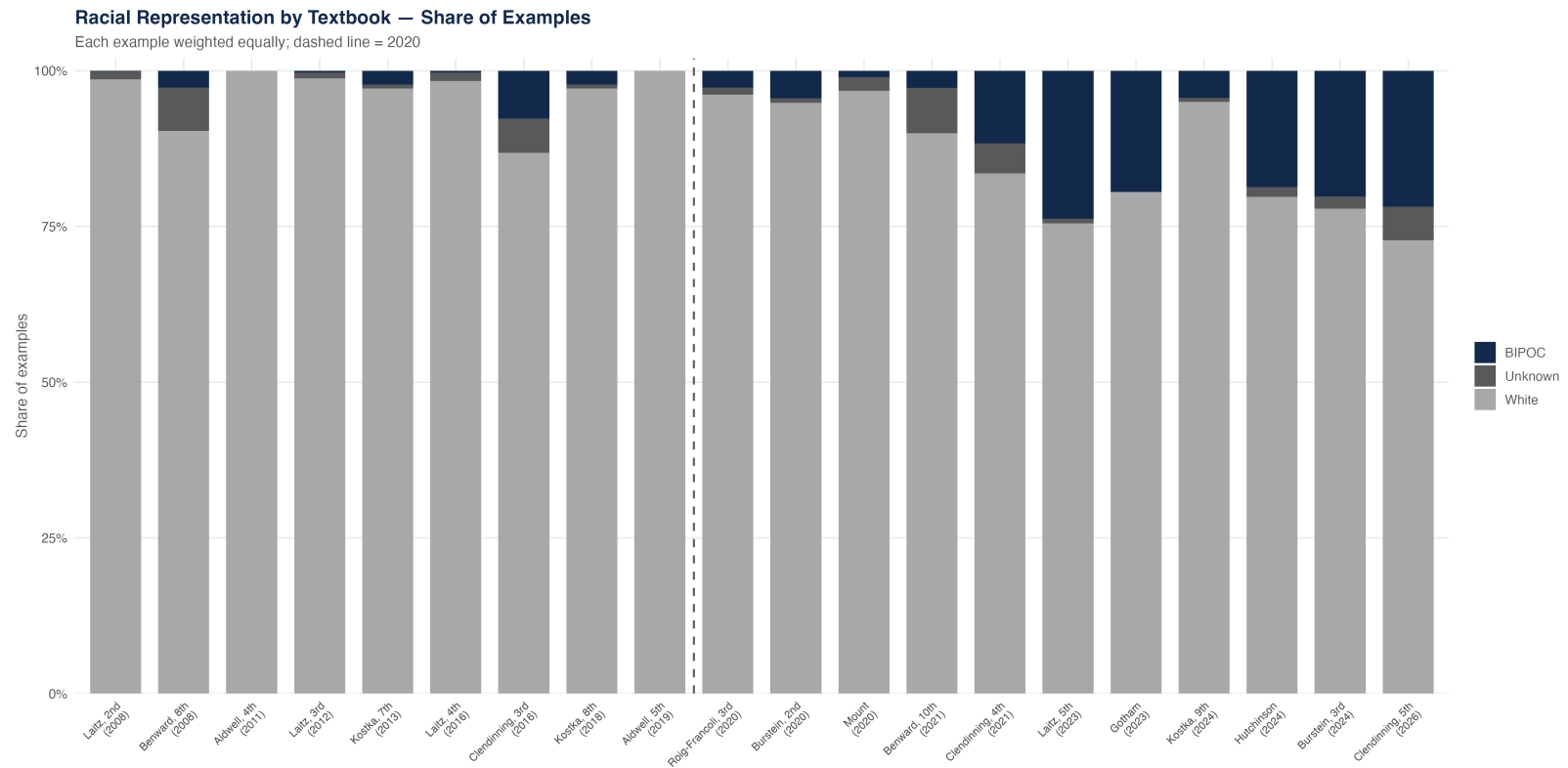


Figure 1: Racial composition of musical examples, by textbook.

1.2. Share of Unique Composers by Race

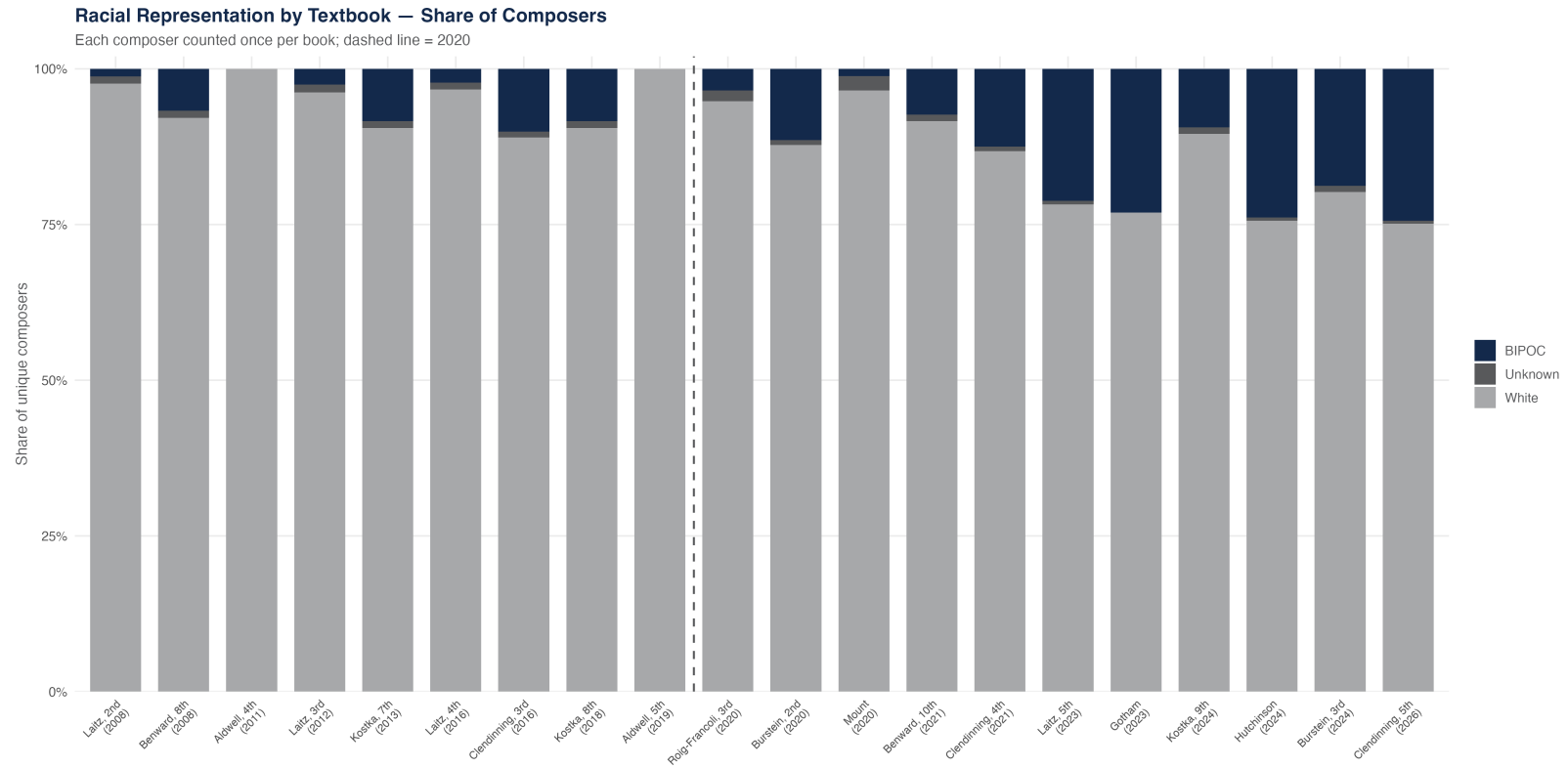


Figure 2: Racial composition of cited composers (unique names), by textbook.

1.3. Racial Representation Across Editions – Examples

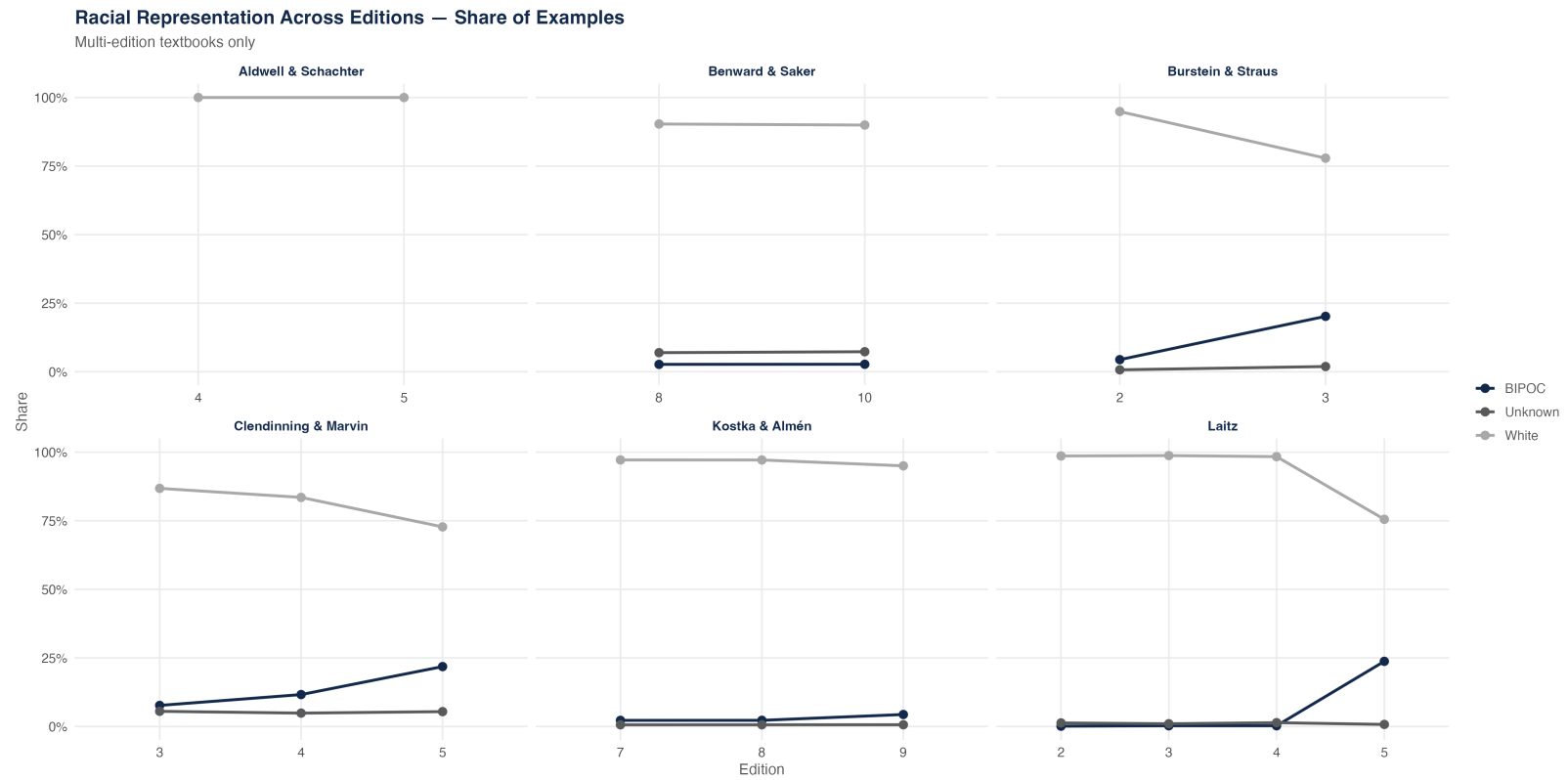


Figure 3: Racial representation across successive editions, measured by share of musical examples. Faceted by textbook; multi-edition books only.

1.4. Racial Representation Across Editions – Composers

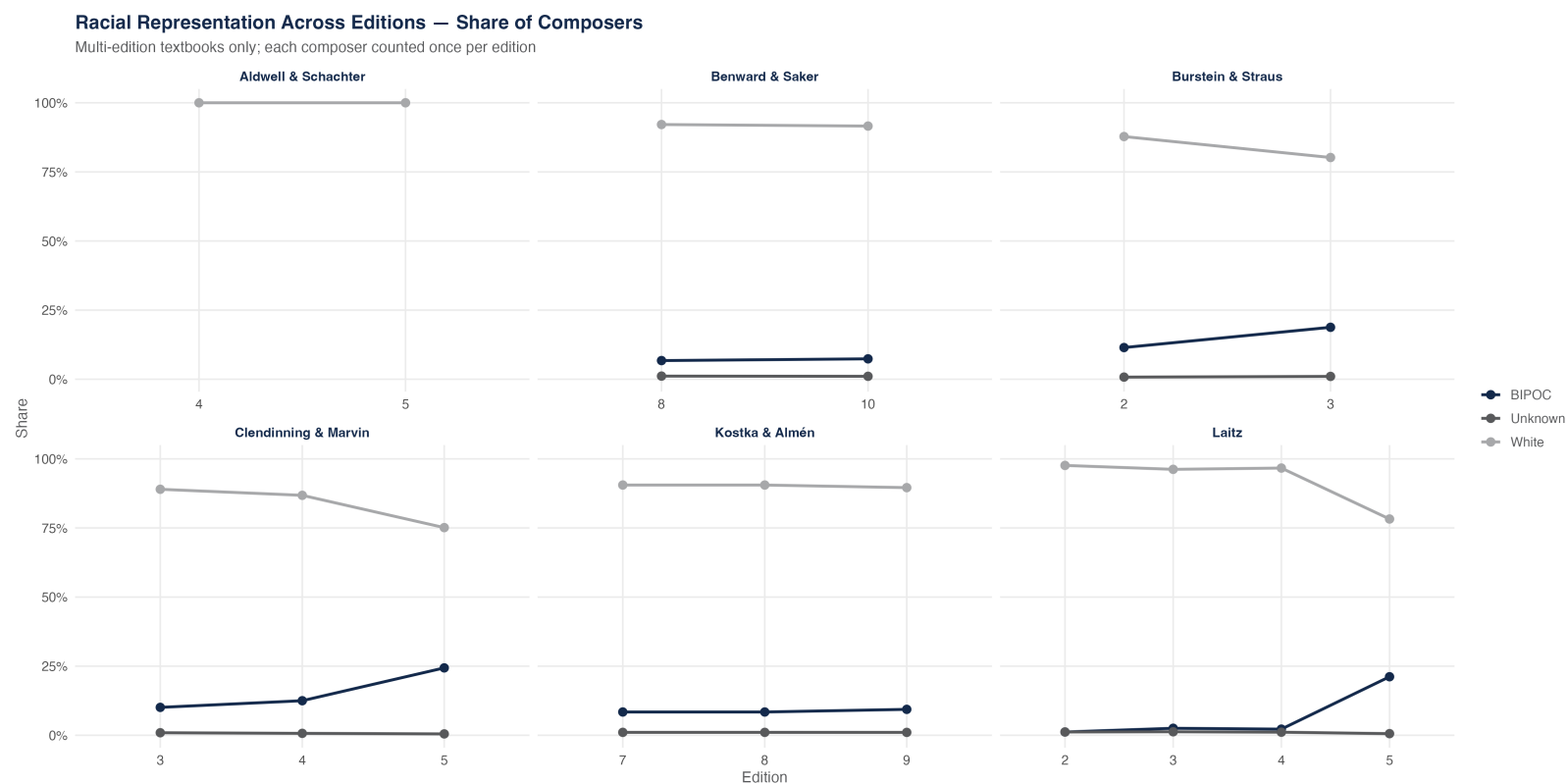


Figure 4: Racial representation across successive editions, measured by share of unique composers. Faceted by textbook; multi-edition books only.

2. Gender Representation

2.1. Share of Musical Examples by Gender

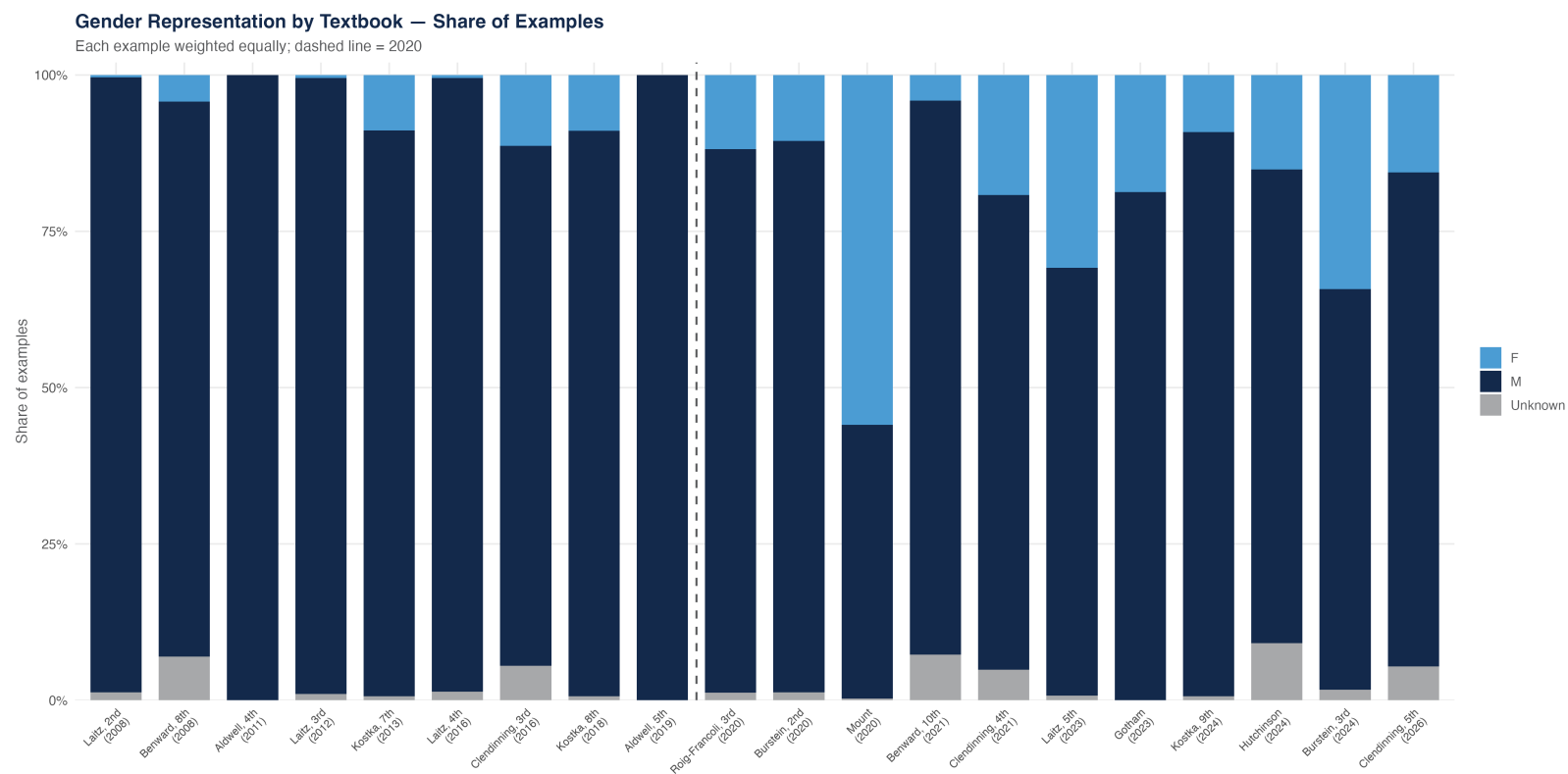


Figure 5: Gender composition of musical examples, by textbook.

2.2. Share of Unique Composers by Gender

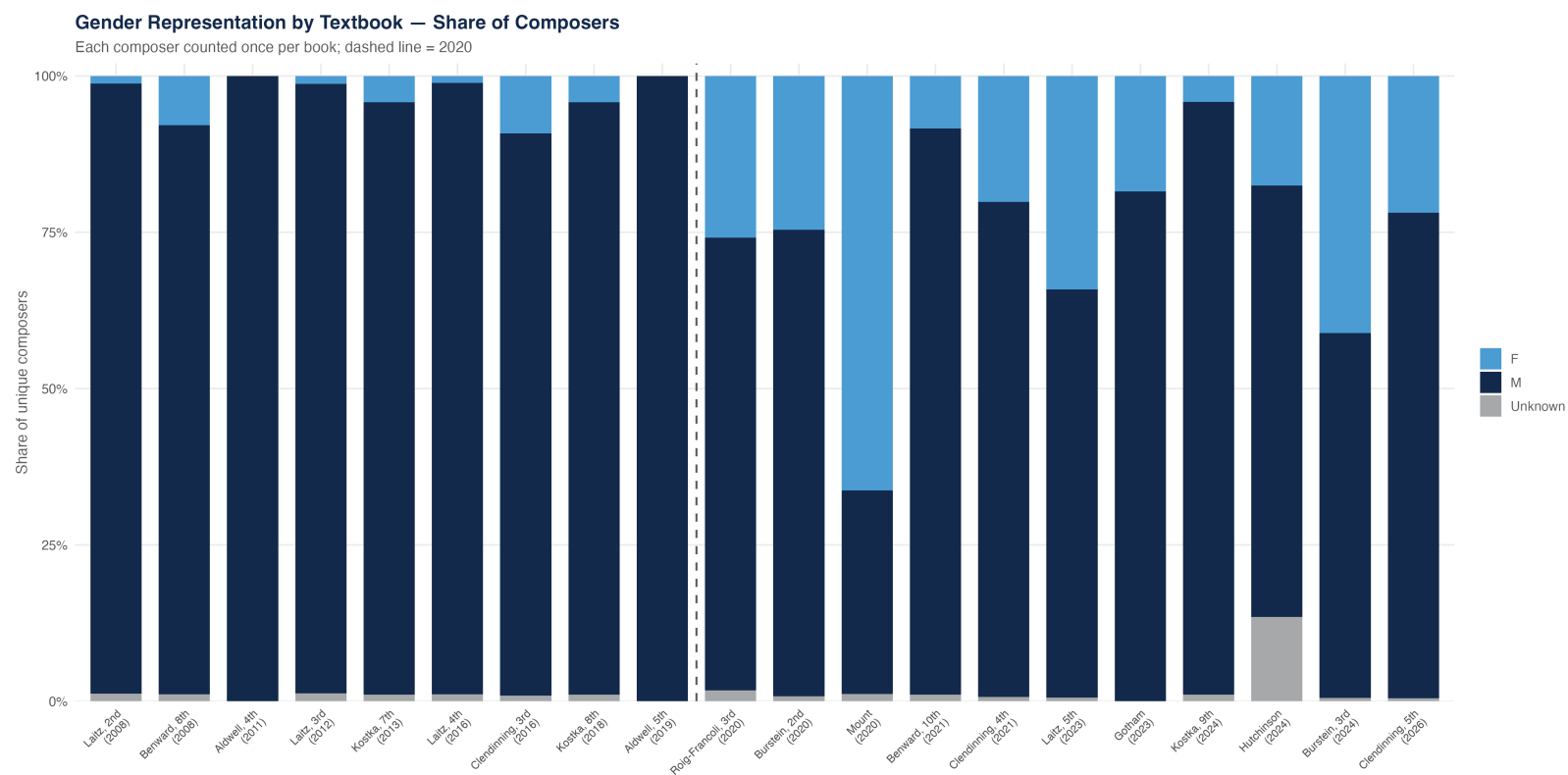


Figure 6: Gender composition of cited composers (unique names), by textbook.

2.3. Gender Representation Across Editions – Examples

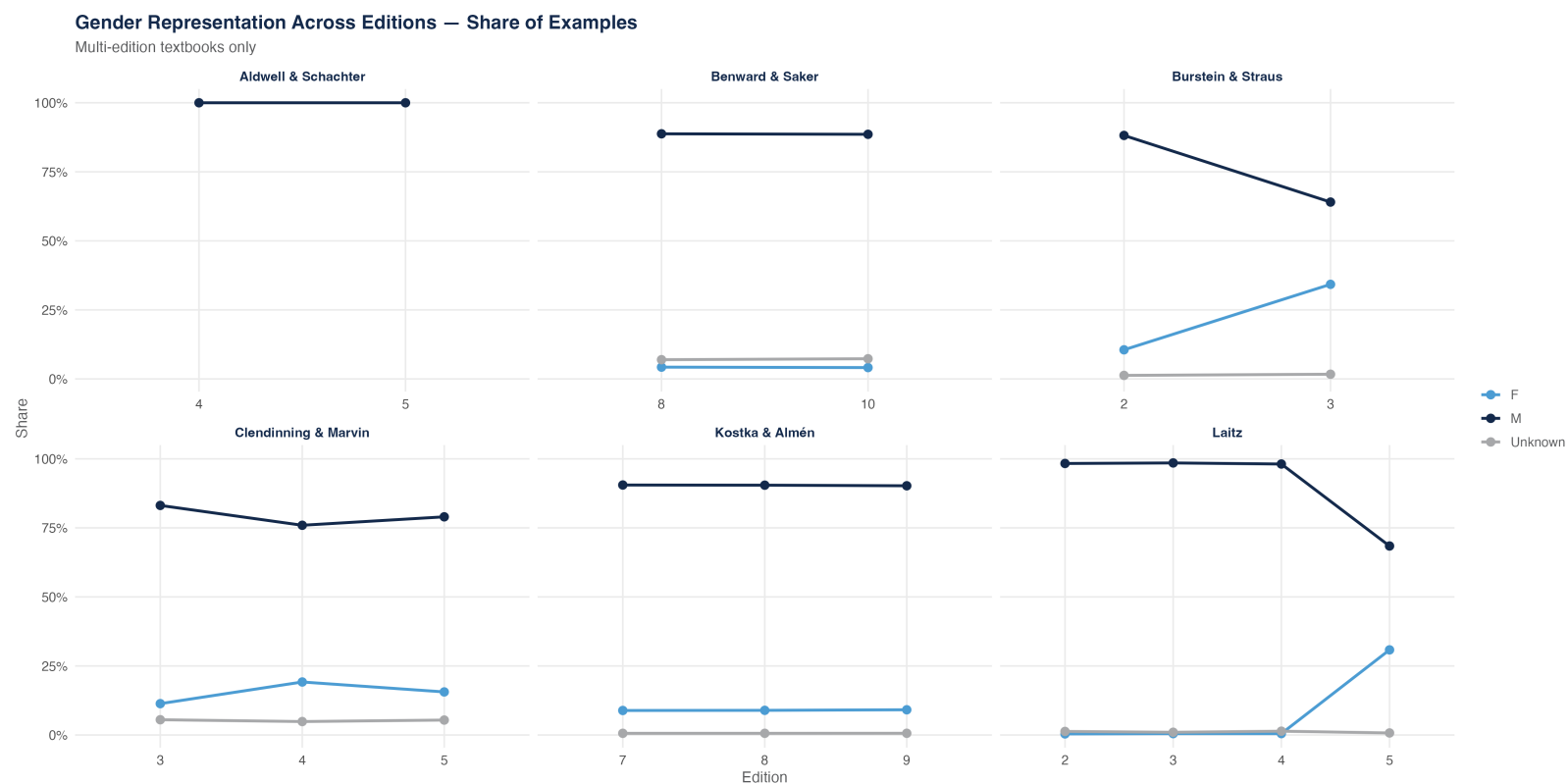


Figure 7: Gender representation across successive editions, measured by share of musical examples. Faceted by textbook; multi-edition books only.

2.4. Gender Representation Across Editions – Composers

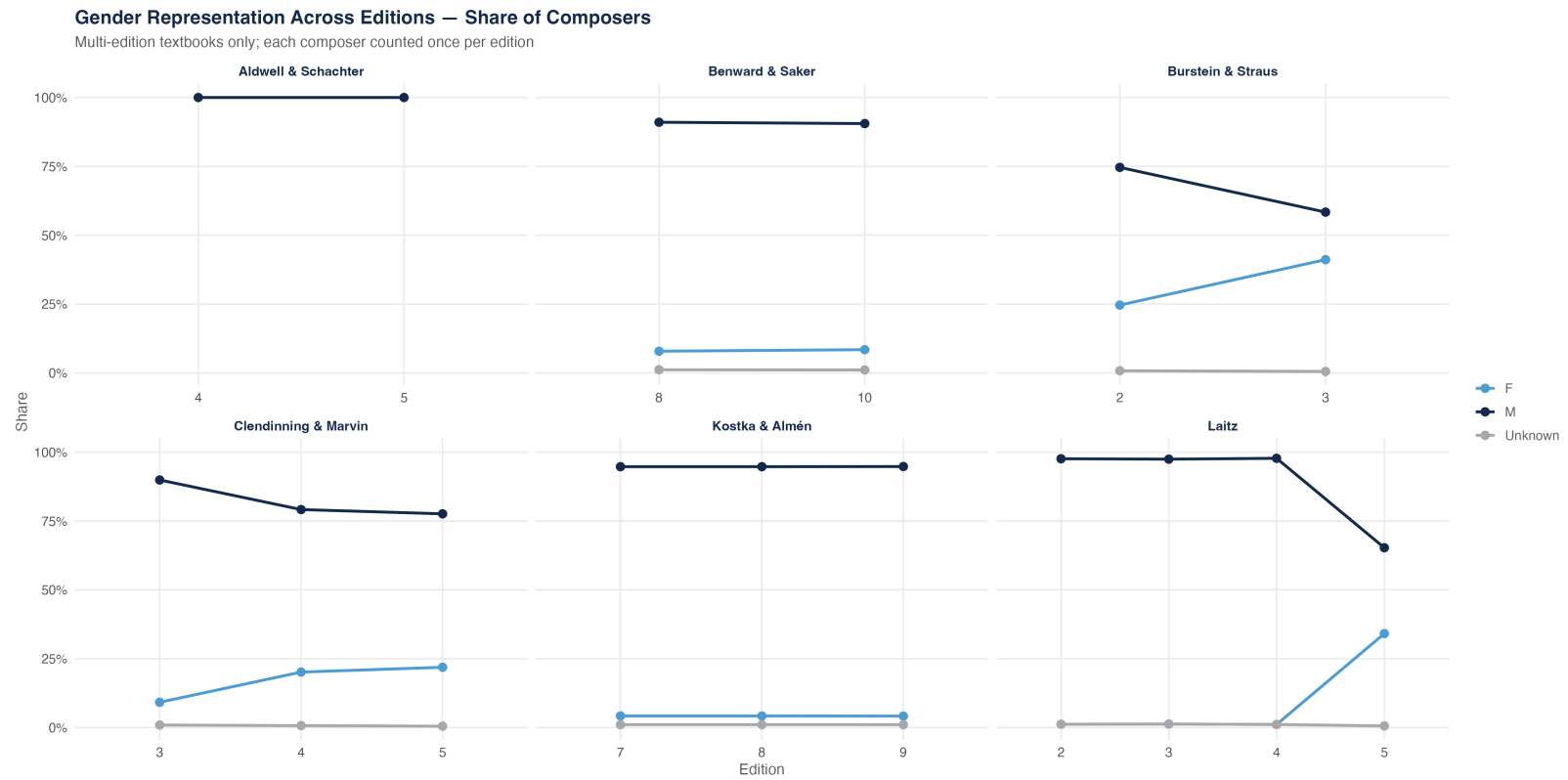


Figure 8: Gender representation across successive editions, measured by share of unique composers. Faceted by textbook; multi-edition books only.

3. Canon Dominance: BHMB

3.1. Bach, Haydn, Mozart, and Beethoven as Share of All Examples

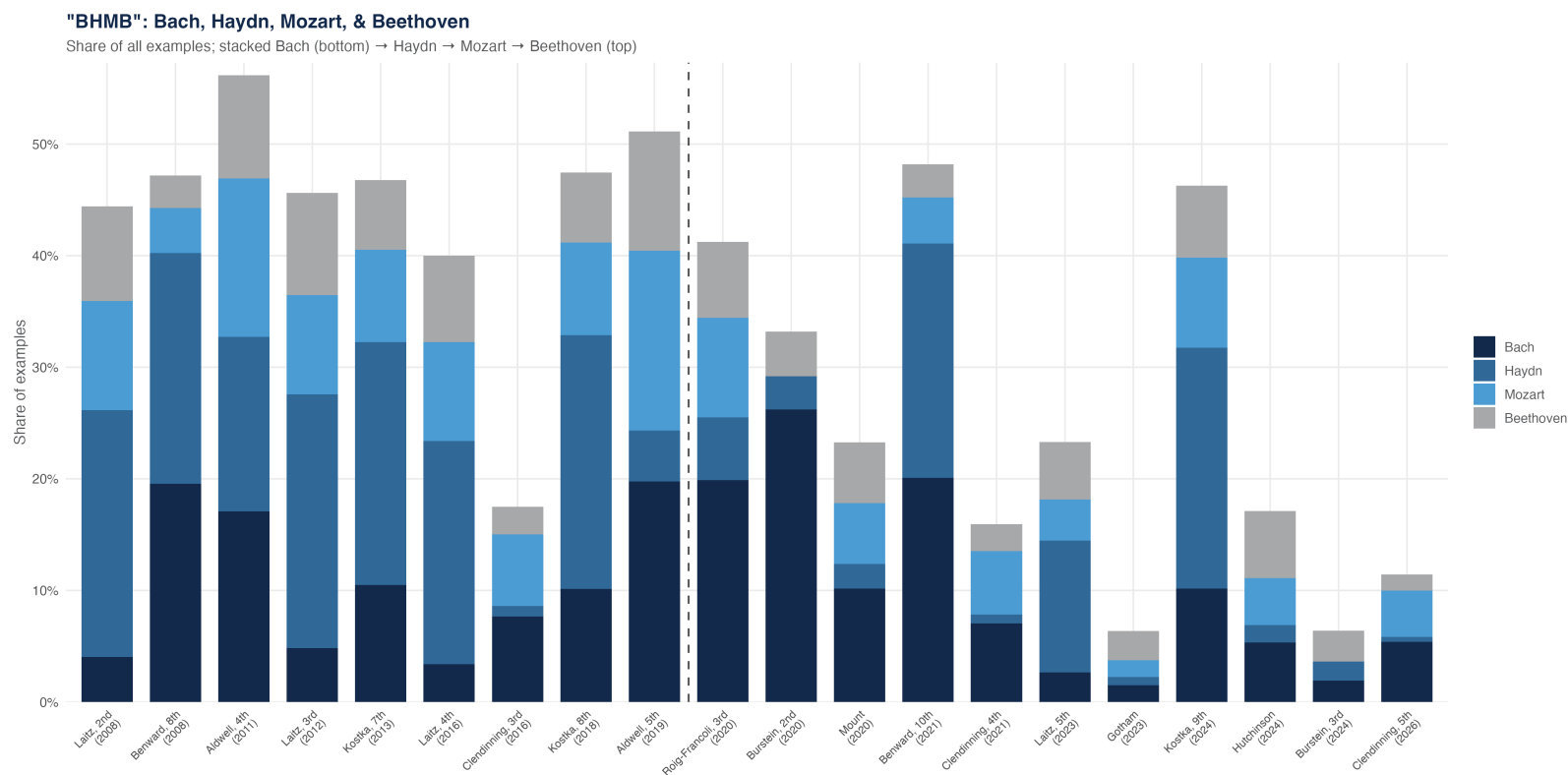


Figure 9: BHMB Quartet: share of all musical examples attributed to Bach, Haydn, Mozart, and Beethoven, by textbook.

The four composers who constitute the BHMB quartet – Bach, Haydn, Mozart, and Beethoven – function as the invisible centre of gravity in the common-practice canon. Across the NLP corpus, the three most-cited dominant composers (Bach, 714 mentions; Mozart, 530; Beethoven, 363) account for 1,607 combined mentions, outpacing all 242 marginalized composers combined (934 total mentions) by a factor of 1.7. Textbooks with higher BHMB percentages devote a structurally disproportionate share of their examples

to a closed set of four names, compressing the space available for any other composer.

4. Tokenization Analysis

Methodological note. “Tokenization” here denotes the pattern in which a textbook acknowledges a demographic group through a small, recurrent handful of composers rather than a genuinely broad roster. Four metrics are used throughout this section:

- **Top-1 share** – the single most-cited composer’s share of all subgroup examples.
- **Breadth ratio** – unique composers $\div$ total subgroup appearances; high = variety, low = repetition of the same names.
- **Within-group Pielou J'** – evenness of the distribution within the subgroup; $J' \rightarrow 1$ means subgroup examples are spread evenly across its composers, $J' \rightarrow 0$ means one composer dominates.
- **Singleton %** – share of subgroup composers appearing only once; high = broad but shallow dipping.

4.1. Top-1 Composer Share Within BIPOC and Female Subgroups

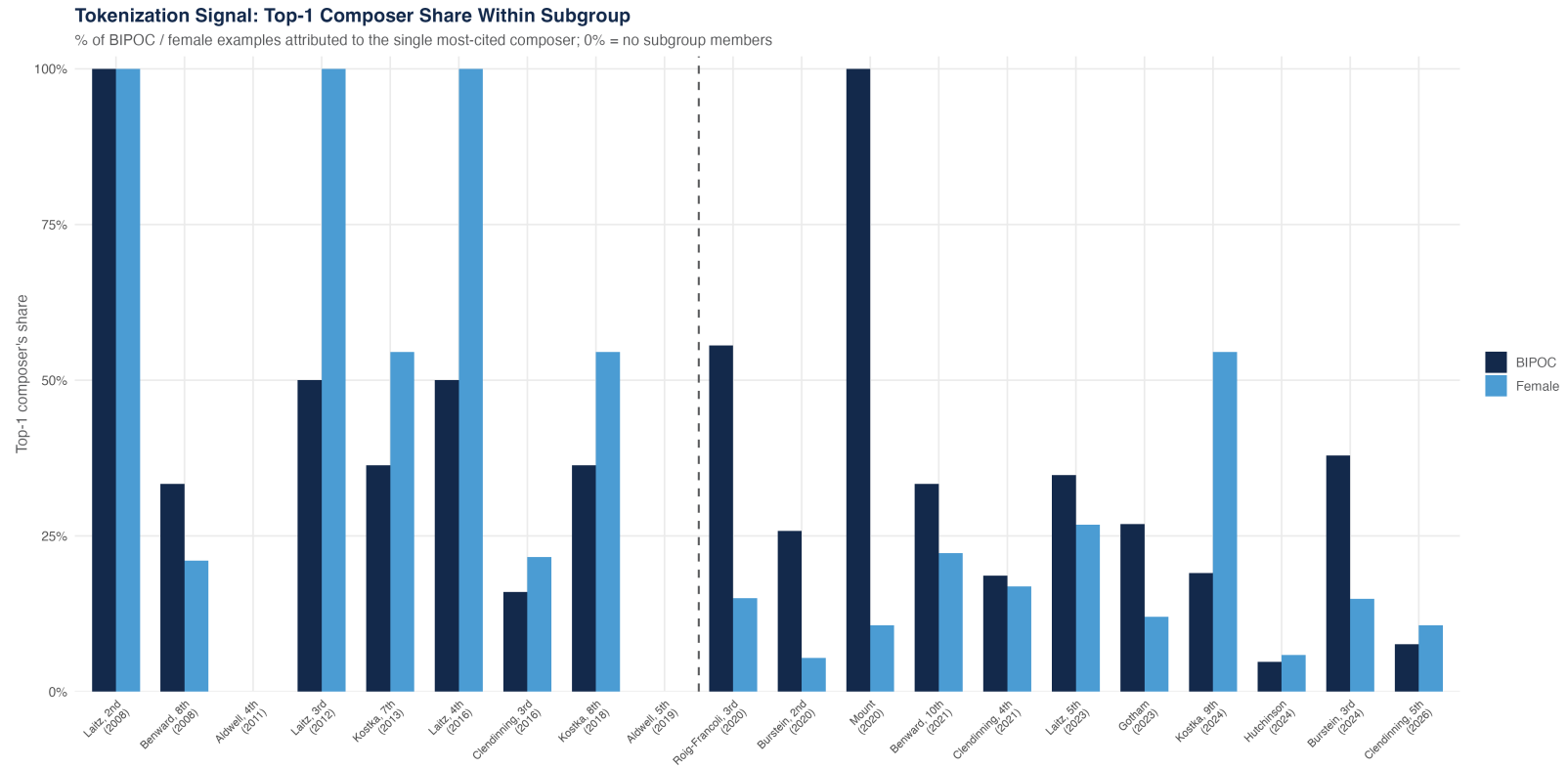


Figure 10: Tokenization signal: share of all BIPOC / female examples attributed to the single most-cited composer, by textbook. Dodged bars; blue = BIPOC, light blue = Female.

4.2. Roster Breadth Within Subgroups

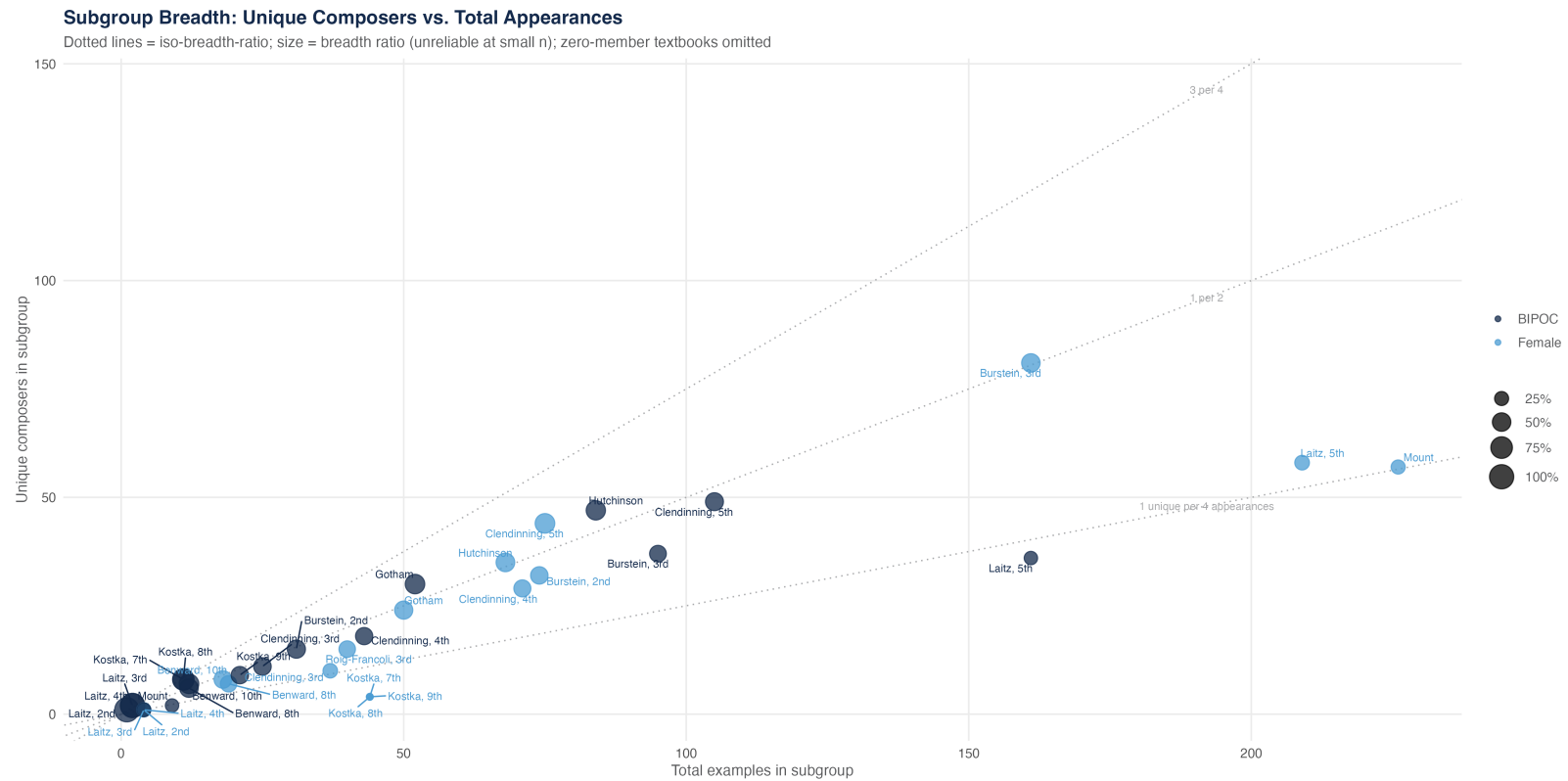


Figure 11: Breadth ratio (unique composers $\div$ total subgroup appearances) for BIPOC and female subgroups, by textbook. Higher values indicate broader, less repetitive representation.

The breadth ratio reveals whether a textbook's diverse examples are genuinely distributed across many composers or concentrated in a handful of names cited repeatedly. Two contrasting patterns emerge.

Hutchinson (2024) and Clendinning's 5th edition (2026) show consistently high BIPOC and female breadth (> 0.46), meaning a substantial proportion of their inclusive examples introduce a different composer each time. At the opposite extreme, Kostka & Almén returns a female breadth of only 0.09 across all three editions: 44 female examples per edition draw on just four women, and this ratio does not change between the 7th (2013), 8th (2018), and 9th (2024) editions – indicating no new female composers were added across three revisions, only repeated citations of the same four names.

Laitz's 5th edition (2023) illustrates a subtler trap. It contains by far the largest BIPOC subgroup in the corpus ($n = 161$), yet its BIPOC breadth is 0.22 – among the lowest for any well-populated edition – meaning those 161 examples draw on 36 composers, with Florence B. Price alone accounting for roughly one-third of appearances.

4.3. Within-Group Evenness vs. Subgroup Size

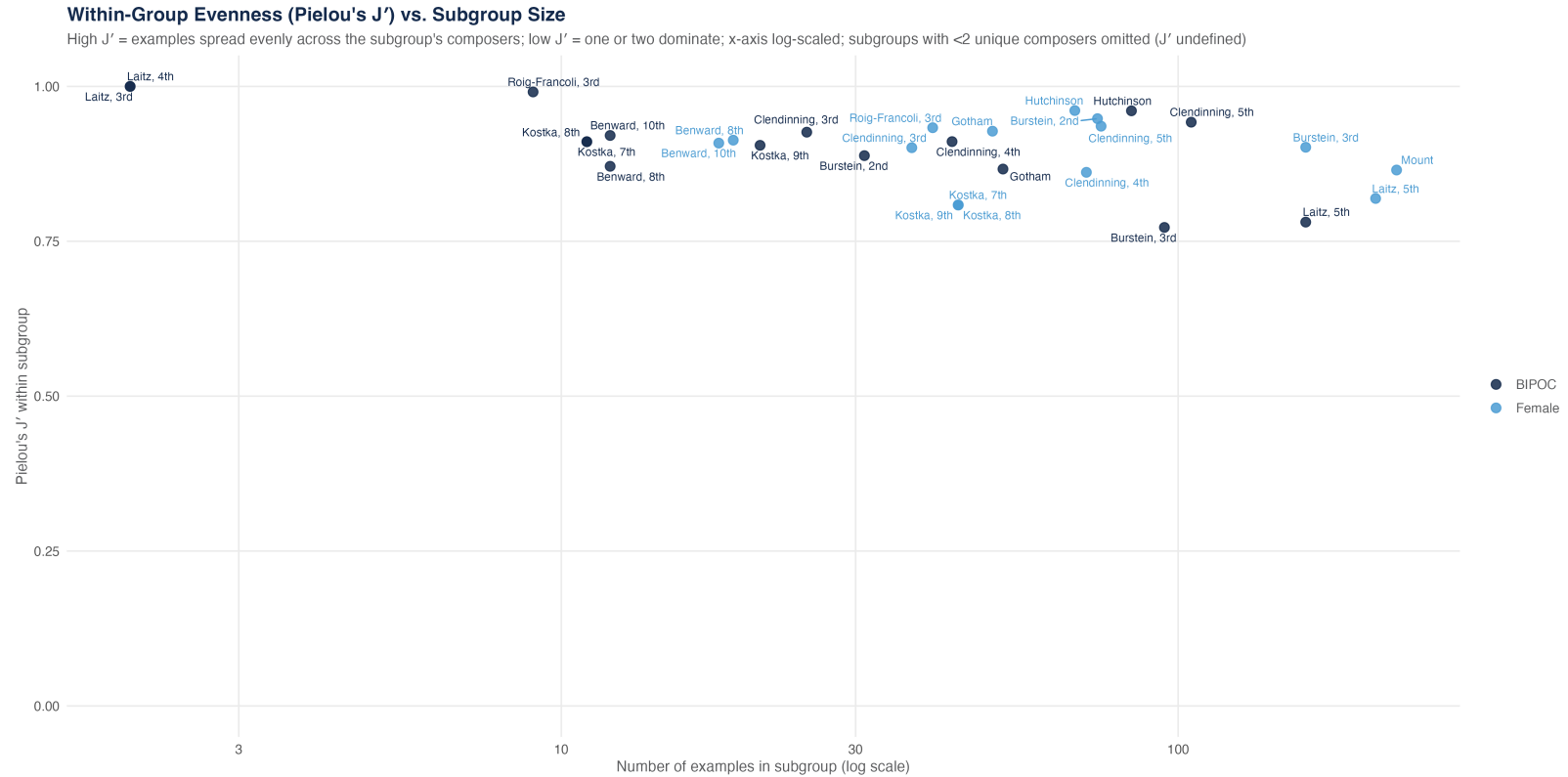


Figure 12: Scatter plot of within-group Pielou evenness (J') against subgroup size (log-scaled x -axis), annotated with textbook names. Low J' with small n signals acute tokenism; low J' with large n signals structural dependence on a very small roster despite high volume.

Within-group Pielou evenness measures how uniformly a subgroup's examples are distributed across its composers on a 0–1 scale, where 1 indicates a perfectly flat distribution and values approaching 0 indicate that a single composer accounts for nearly everything. Reading the scatter jointly with log-scaled subgroup size identifies two qualitatively different forms of tokenism.

Small- n tokenism (lower-left): entries with very low evenness and tiny subgroups – Laitz 2nd–4th BIPOC ($n = 1$ –2), Mount BIPOC ($n = 4$), and Roig-Francolí BIPOC ($n = 9$) – reflect textbooks where a subgroup is present in name only, often through a single composer cited a handful of times.

Large- n tokenism (lower-right): Kostka & Almén's female subgroup is the clearest case of low evenness persisting at scale. Despite 44 female examples per edition, four composers account for 91% of them – and the distribution does not budge across the 7th, 8th, and 9th editions.

The healthiest distributions – high J' at large n – belong to Hutchinson ($n = 84$ BIPOC) and Clendinning 5th ($n = 105$ BIPOC). Laitz 5th sits between the poles: its large BIPOC ($n = 161$) and female ($n = 209$) subgroups are the most distributed in the corpus at scale, yet Florence B. Price still accounts for roughly 35% of BIPOC appearances, making her the corpus-wide “token” even in the most inclusive book.

4.4. Tokenization Across Editions

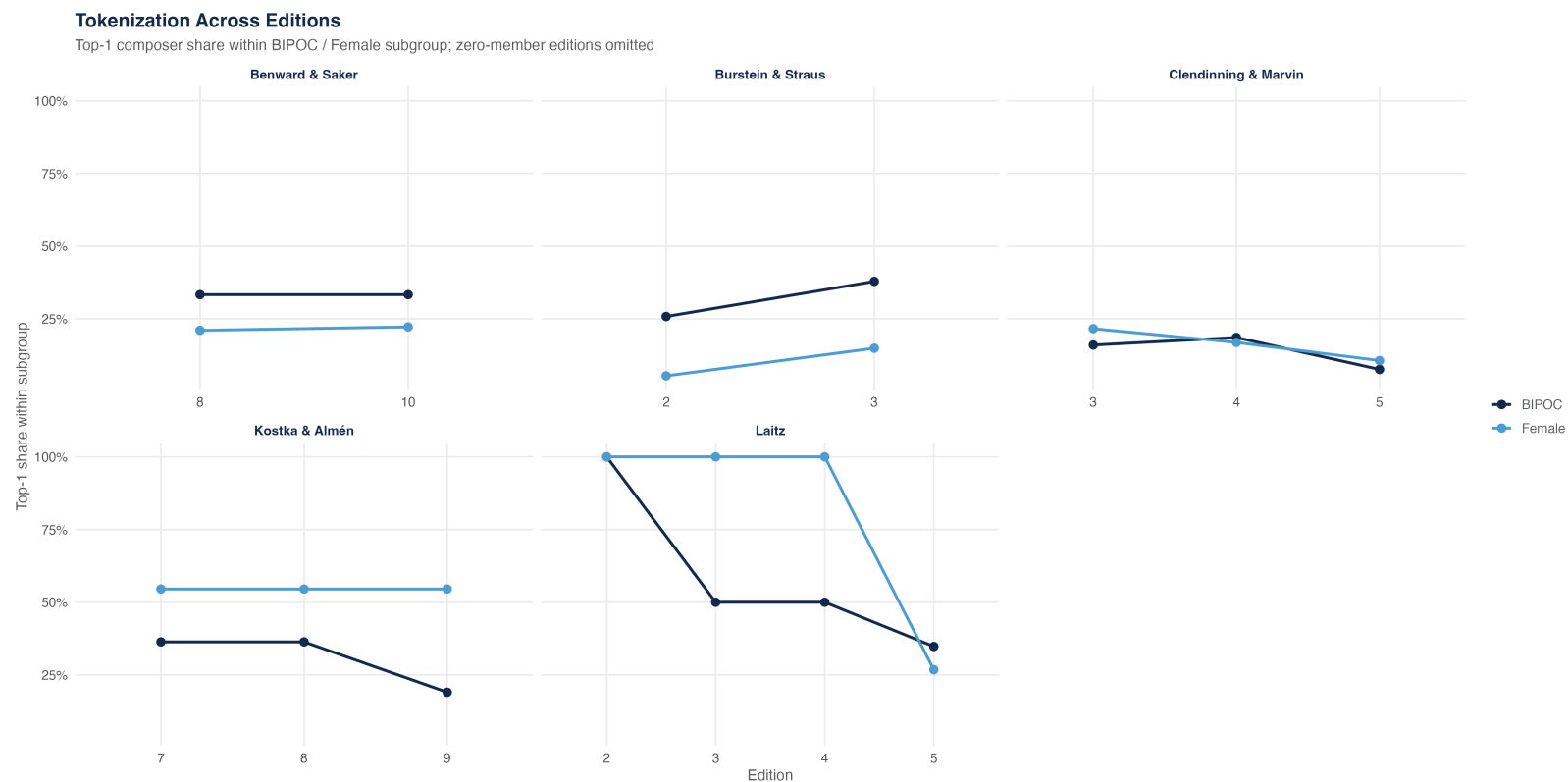


Figure 13: Change in top-1 share and breadth ratio across successive editions, faceted by textbook. Tracks whether newer editions have genuinely diversified their subgroup rosters or merely added volume to the same composers.

4.5. Who Are the “Token” Composers?

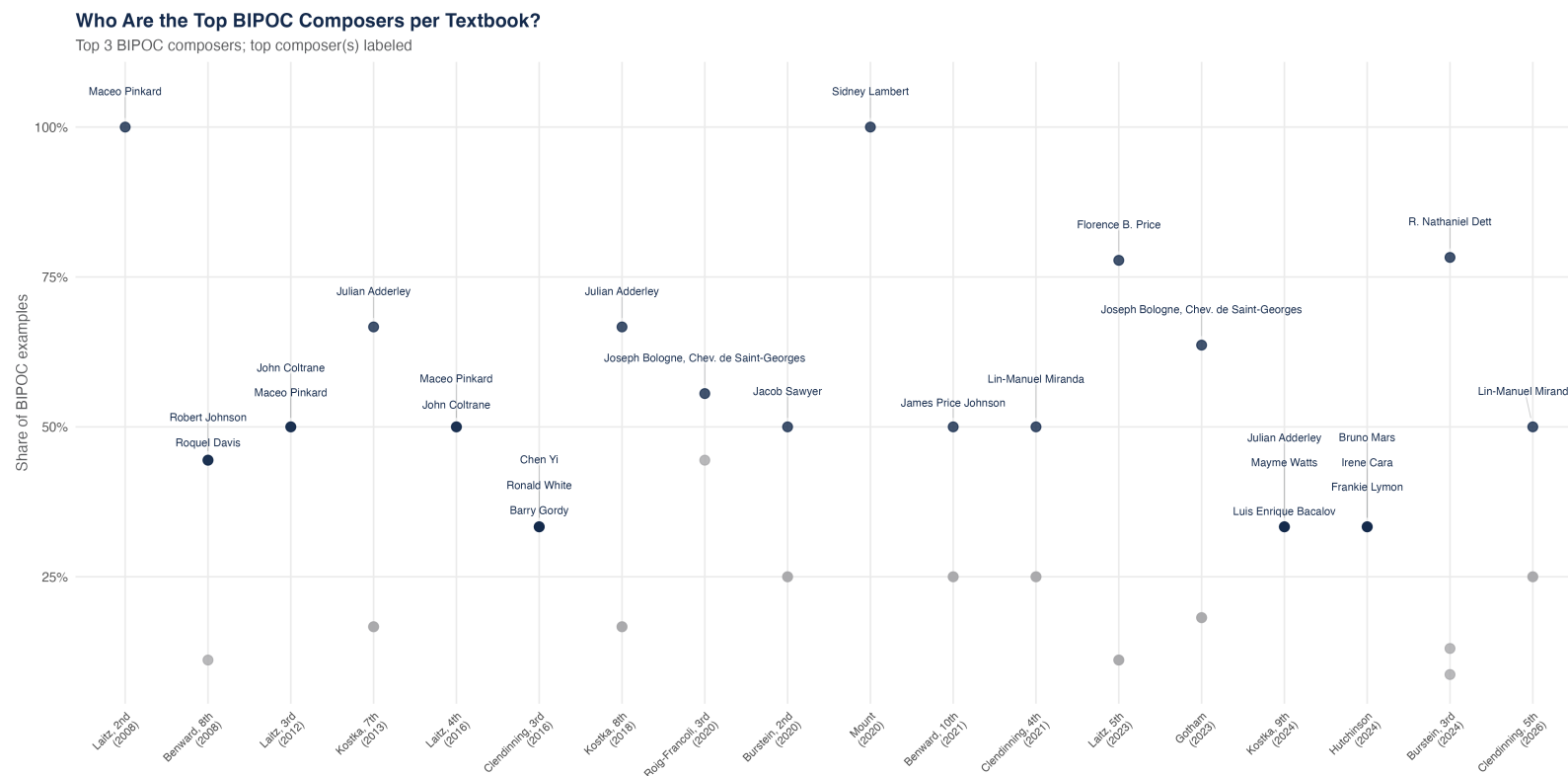


Figure 14: Top-5 most-cited composers within the BIPOC and female subgroups per textbook. Reveals which individual names carry the weight of “diverse” representation.

This figure names the individual composers who bear the representational weight of each textbook’s claim to diversity. Composers like Florence B. Price, Tania León, and Samuel Coleridge-Taylor appear repeatedly across the corpus, with Price dominating marginalized-composer passages in Laitz (2023) – 164 of the 512 total marginalized passages (32.0%) in the ten-book NLP corpus reside in that single textbook. When a small handful of composers carry the entire burden of a book’s “diversity,” the breadth-ratio metric collapses and the tokenism pattern is confirmed: the book is not representing a community of composers but gesturing toward one through a few prominent names.

5. Corpus-Wide Diversity: Pielou Evenness

Pielou's J' , borrowed from ecology, summarizes how evenly each textbook distributes its examples across the full composer roster independent of repertoire size.

Pielou's J' (evenness). J' is the ratio of the observed Shannon entropy $H' = -\sum_i p_i \ln p_i$ to the theoretical maximum $\ln n$, where p_i is the share of examples attributed to composer i and n is the total number of unique composers: $J' = H' / \ln n$. It originated in ecology to compare species distributions across habitats of different sizes. Applied here, $J' = 1.0$ means every composer in the book appears with equal frequency, i.e., a perfectly flat distribution. $J' \rightarrow 0$ means a single composer accounts for nearly all examples. Values above ≈ 0.90 indicate a broadly distributed repertoire; values below ≈ 0.73 indicate notable concentration in a small cluster of composers. Because J' is normalized by roster size, a 400-example book and a 1,000-example book are directly comparable.

Textbook	J'	Comment
Aldwell, 4th (2011)	0.708	
Aldwell, 5th (2019)	0.713	
Benward, 8th (2008)	0.741	
Benward, 10th (2021)	0.728	
Burstein, 2nd (2020)	0.700	Third lowest in corpus
Burstein, 3rd (2024)	0.901	Third highest
Clendinning, 3rd (2016)	0.898	Best evenness pre-2023
Clendinning, 4th (2021)	0.894	
Clendinning, 5th (2026)	0.919	Fourth highest
Gotham (2023)	0.943	<i>Highest in corpus</i>
Hutchinson (2024)	0.925	Second highest
Kostka, 7th (2013)	0.727	
Kostka, 8th (2018)	0.722	
Kostka, 9th (2024)	0.728	

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Textbook	J'	Comment
Laitz, 2nd (2008)	0.673	Second lowest in corpus
Laitz, 3rd (2012)	0.669	<i>Lowest in corpus</i>
Laitz, 4th (2016)	0.706	
Laitz, 5th (2023)	0.843	
Mount (2020)	0.853	
Roig-Francolí, 3rd (2020)	0.809	

J' : 1.0 = perfectly even; $\rightarrow 0$ = one composer dominates. Higher J' indicates a healthier, more evenly distributed repertoire. Sorted alphabetically by author.

6. Geographic Distribution

6.1. Continental Origin of Examples

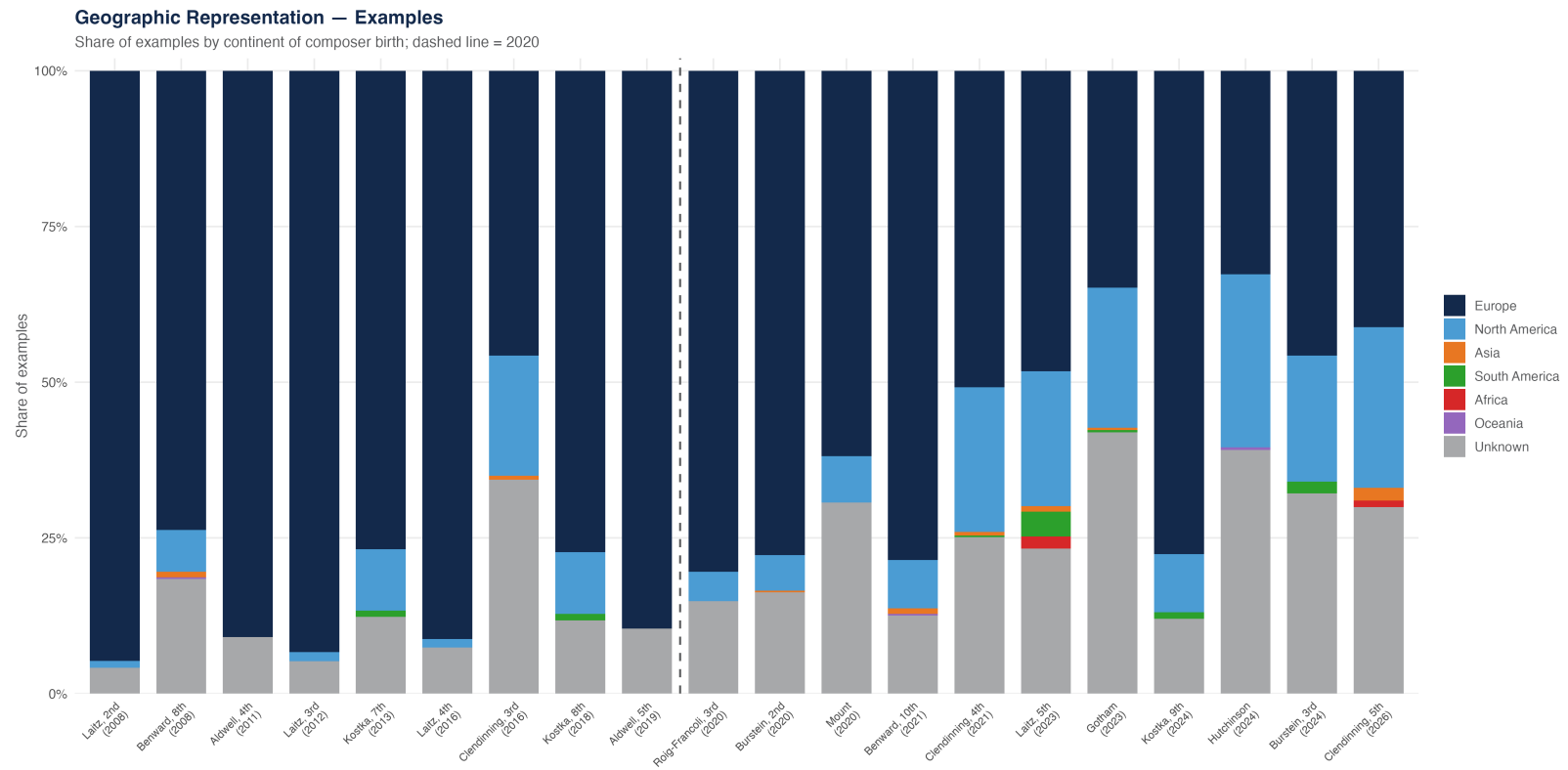


Figure 15: Continental origin of musical examples, by textbook.

6.2. Continental Origin of Cited Composers

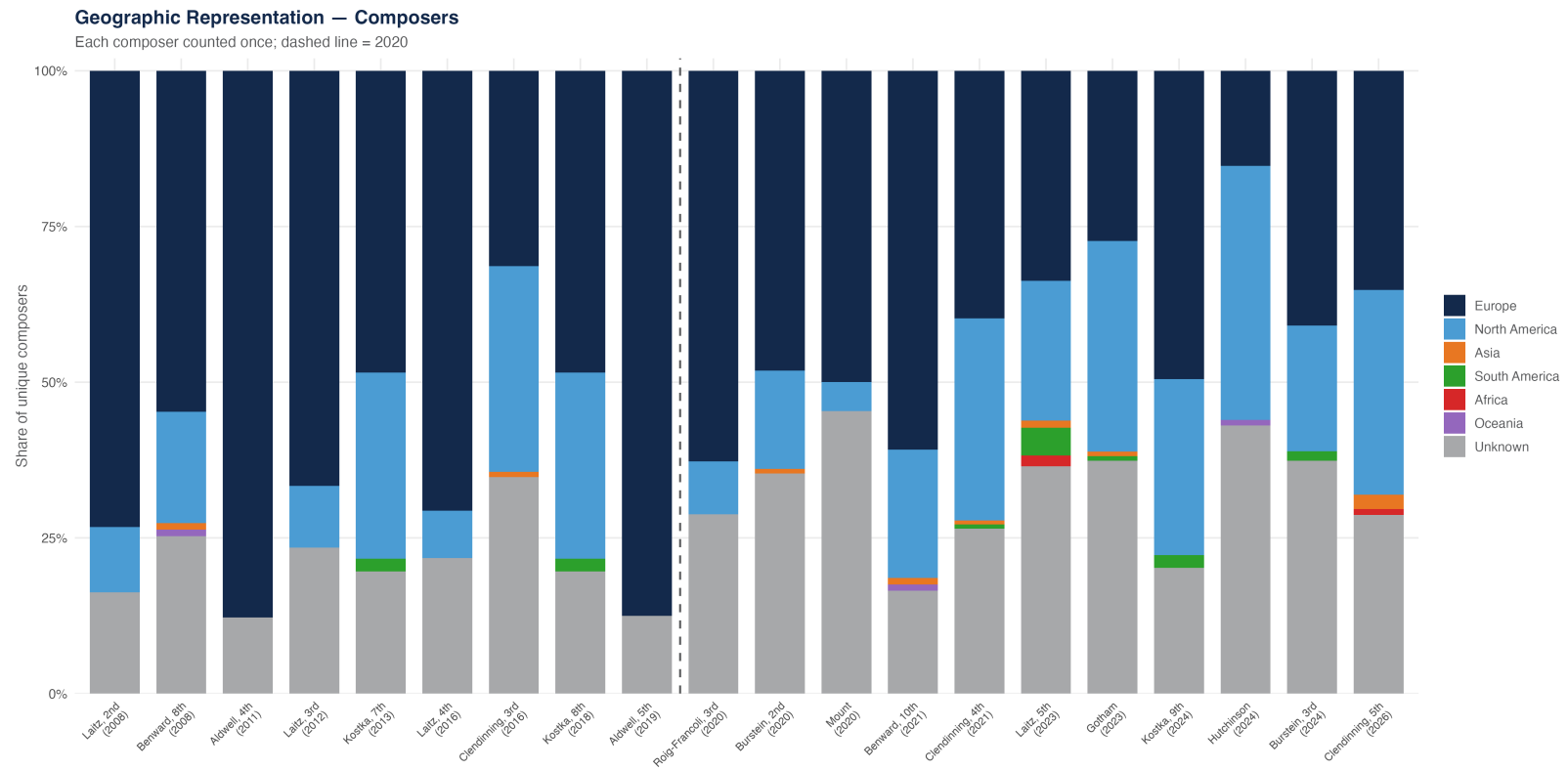


Figure 16: Continental origin of unique cited composers, by textbook.

6.3. Mean Composer Location per Textbook

Mean Composer Birthplace per Textbook

Centroid of all geo-coded composers; color = publication year (blue = older, amber = newer)



Figure 17: World map showing the mean geographic centroid of cited composers per textbook, weighted by mention count.

6.4. Distance from Vienna: Distribution by Textbook

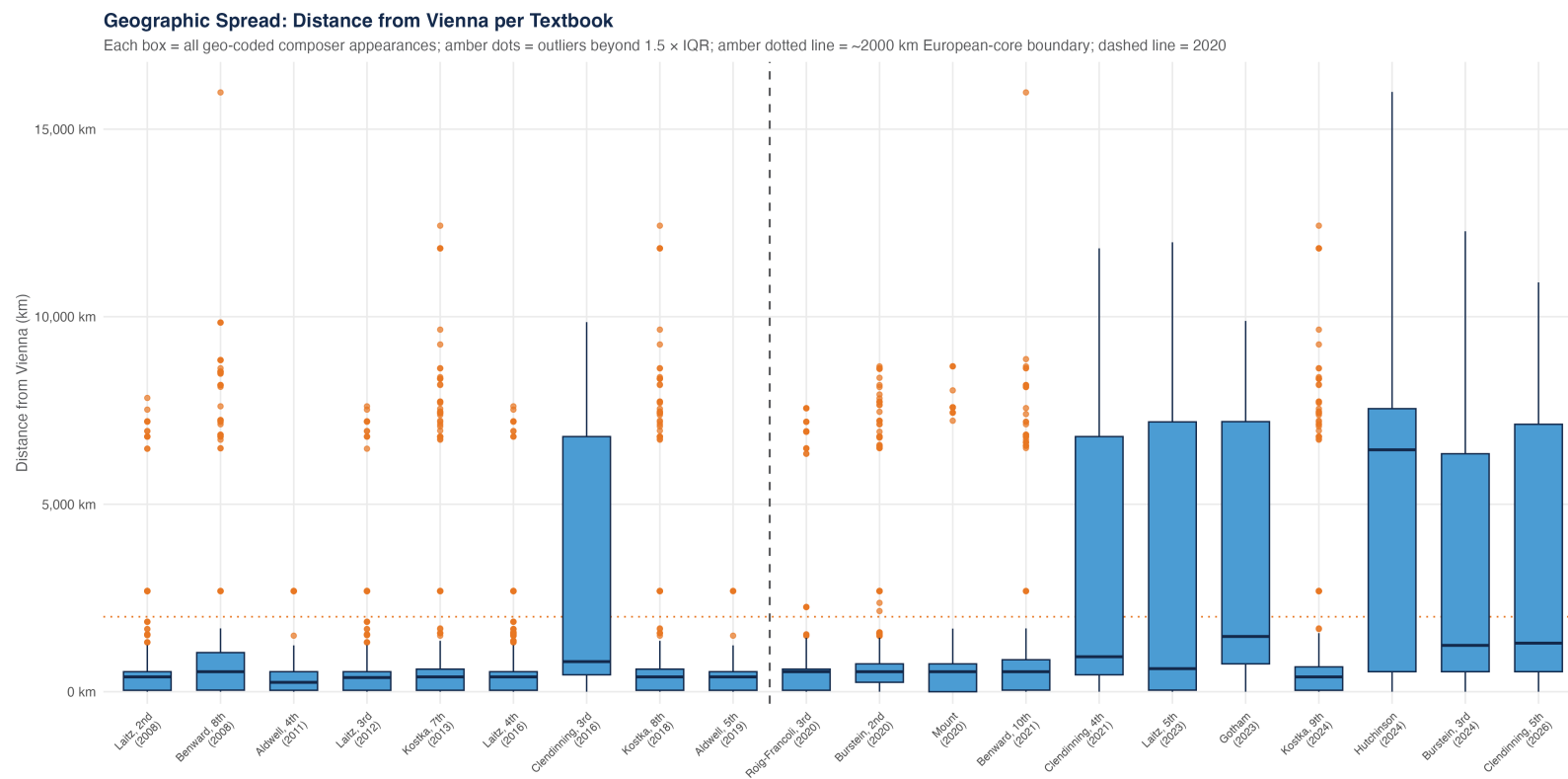


Figure 18: Boxplot of composer distances from Vienna (km) per textbook (proximity to Vienna approximates the degree of Austro-Germanic canon concentration). Each box shows the median and interquartile range of birth-location distances, with individual composers as jittered points. Textbooks with narrower, lower boxes are more geographically concentrated around the Austro-German core.

6.5. Share of Composers Born Beyond 2,000 km from Vienna

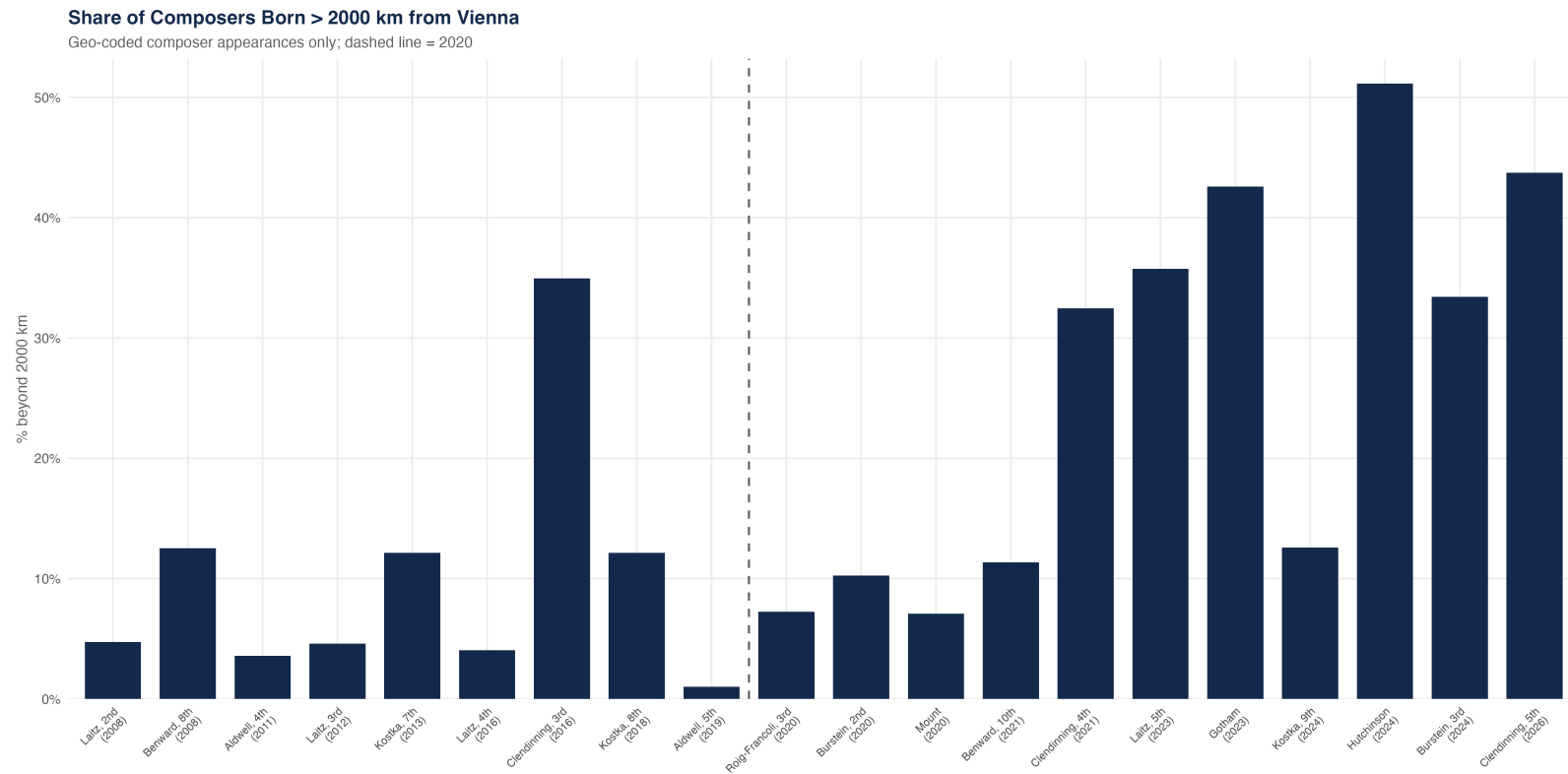


Figure 19: Percentage of cited composers (by mention count) born more than 2,000 km from Vienna, by textbook. Serves as a simple binary measure of geographic reach beyond the Austro-German and Western European core.

6.6. Geographic Spread vs. Composer Diversity

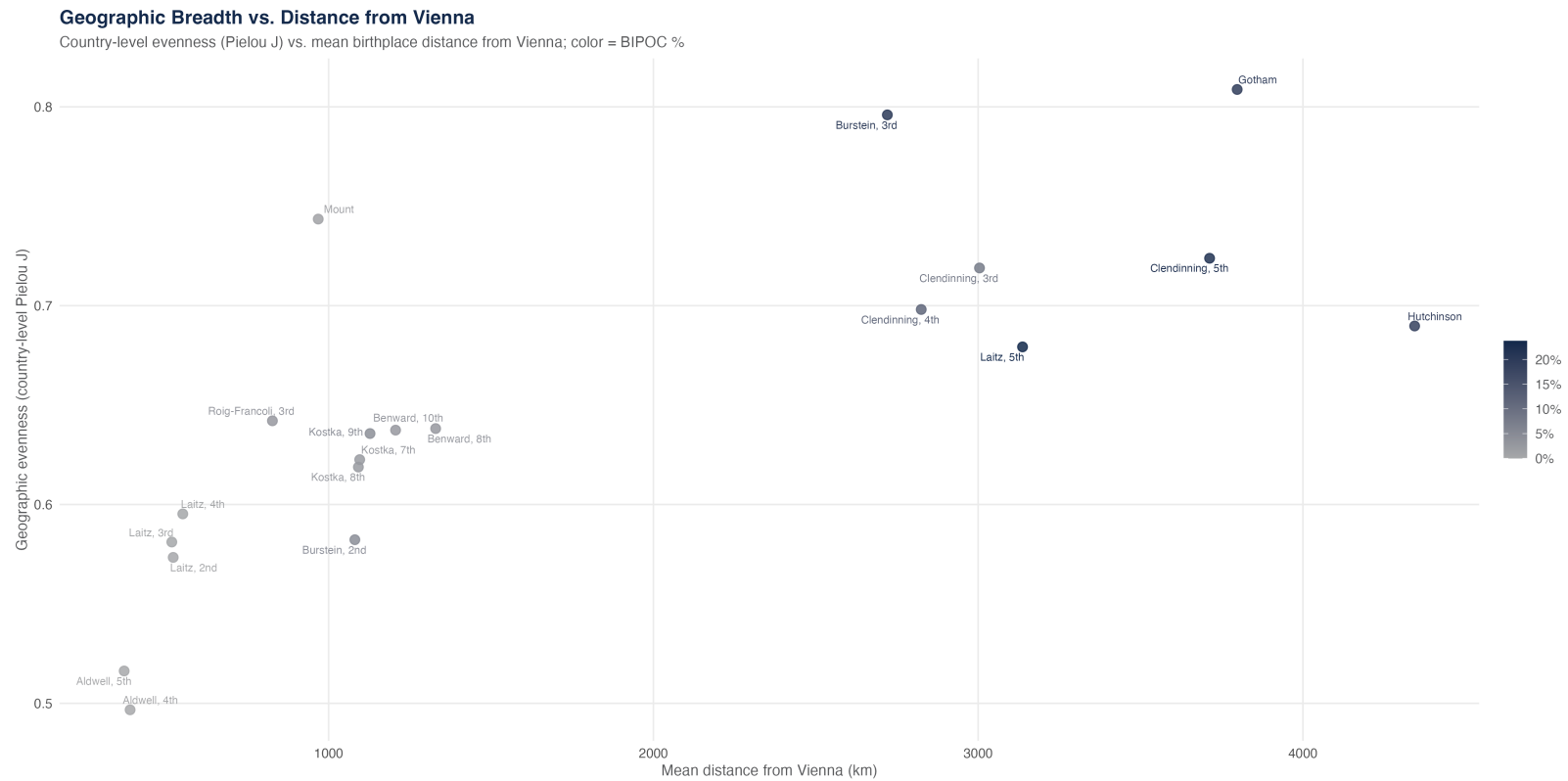


Figure 20: Scatter plot of geographic spread (mean distance from Vienna) against overall composer diversity (Shannon evenness), annotated by textbook. Upper-right quadrant indicates both geographic and compositional breadth.

6.7. Geographic Tokenization: Top-1 National Origin Share

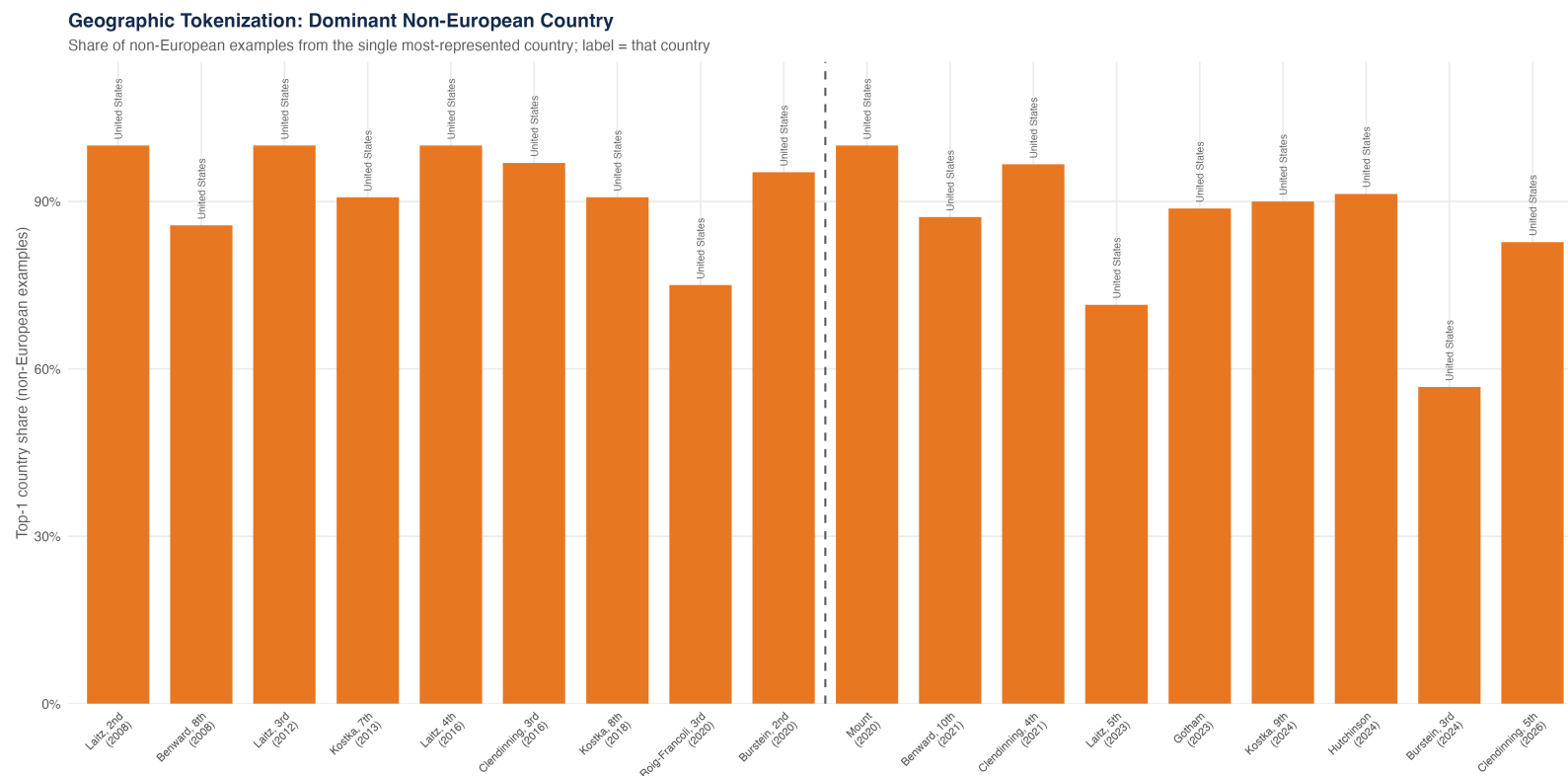


Figure 21: Share of examples attributed to composers from the single most-represented birth country, by textbook. A high top-1 share indicates that geographic diversity, where it exists, is itself concentrated in a single nation.

For every textbook, when a composer from outside of Europe is used, the most likely country of origin – by far – is the USA.

Part Two: NLP Framing Analysis

Passage-level computational analysis of how marginalized composers are framed across the most recent editions of ten core music-theory textbooks

Analytical architecture. The framing analysis operates on 6,313 textbook passages processed by a three-tier NLP pipeline: (1) a lexicon-rule backbone with category-specific weighted regex patterns; (2) a TF-IDF support layer using prototype-centroid cosine similarity; and (3) a BERT sentence-embedding layer (*BGE-large-en-v1.5*) for neutral-label refinement, unsupervised clustering, and rule-validity auditing. Four framing categories are assigned:

Category	Definition
Normative	The example illustrates how a concept <i>typically</i> works; the composer’s music is treated as a natural instance of standard procedure.
Additive	The example extends or varies a concept already established through other (usually dominant) examples – the “and also…” register.
Exceptional	The example is framed as a deviation, special case, or curiosity; language marks the music as unusual or distinctive.
Corrective	The example is cited to acknowledge historical exclusion or to name prior marginalization – an explicit act of recognition.

7. Musical Tradition Representation

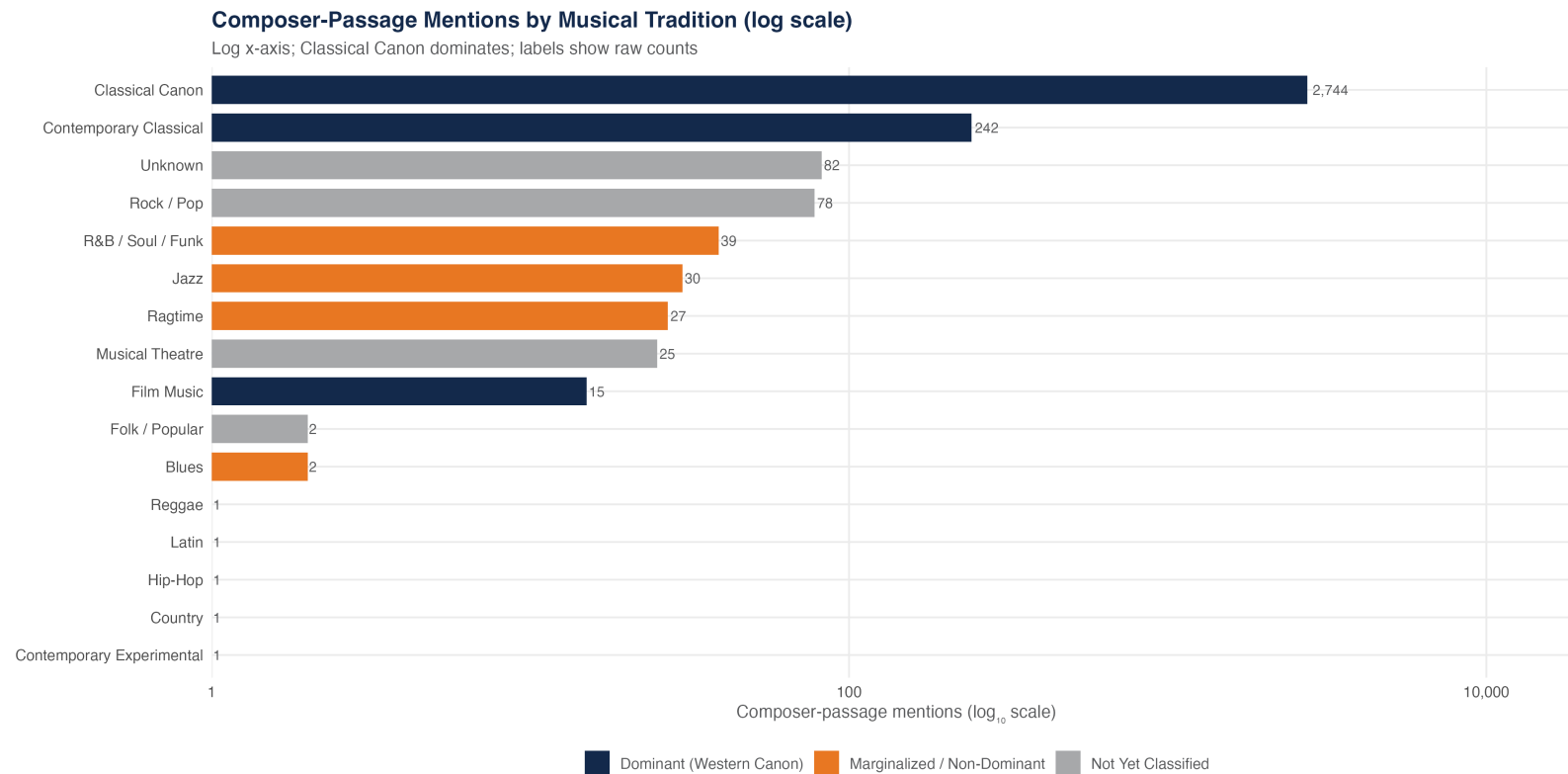


Figure 22: Representation by musical tradition: total passage mentions per tradition category (Classical / Common-Practice, Jazz, Popular, Non-Western, etc.), log-scaled x -axis.

The NLP corpus reflects the same structural hierarchy visible in the Part One counts: the Western classical / common-practice tradition dominates overwhelmingly, with all other traditions – jazz, popular music, non-Western idioms – appearing at a fraction of the volume. The log scale is necessary because classical mentions exceed 500 while most other traditions fall below 100, making linear scaling uninformative.

8. Gender Distribution

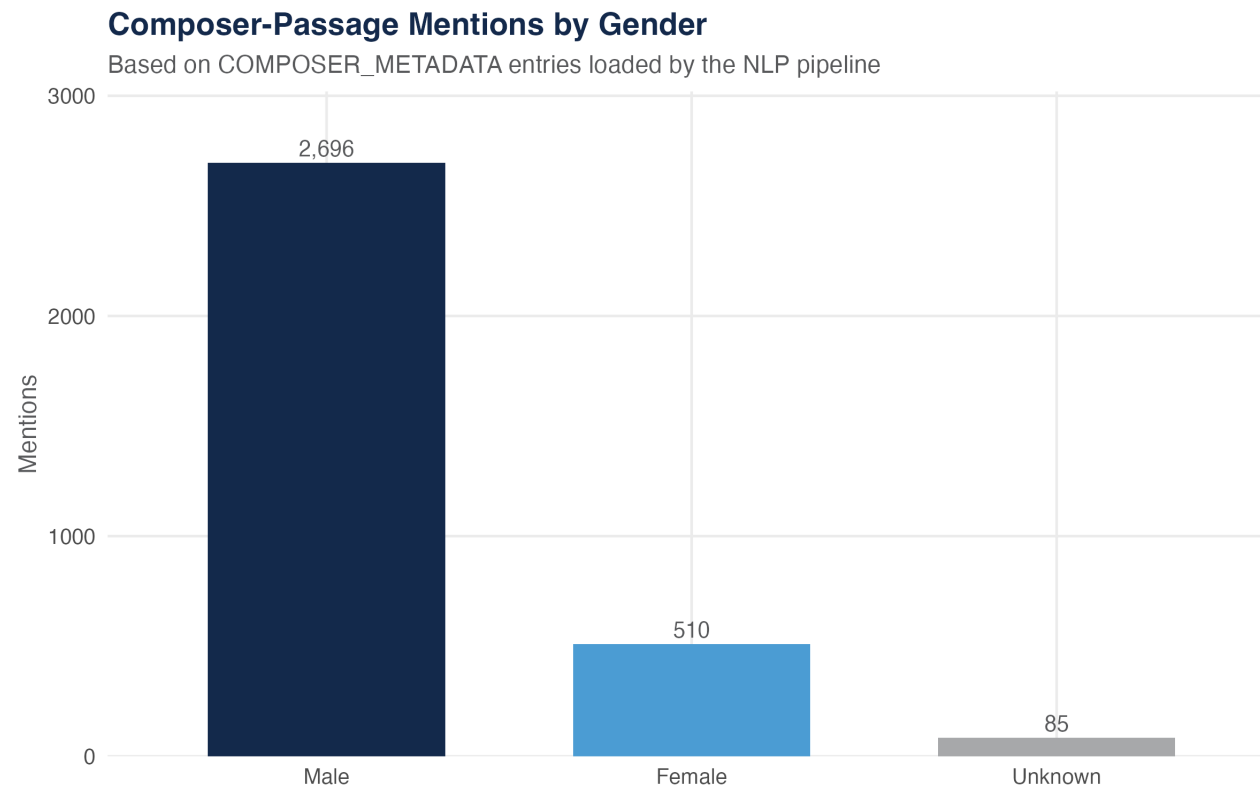


Figure 23: Gender distribution of passage mentions across the NLP corpus.

9. Historical Era

9.1. Era Totals

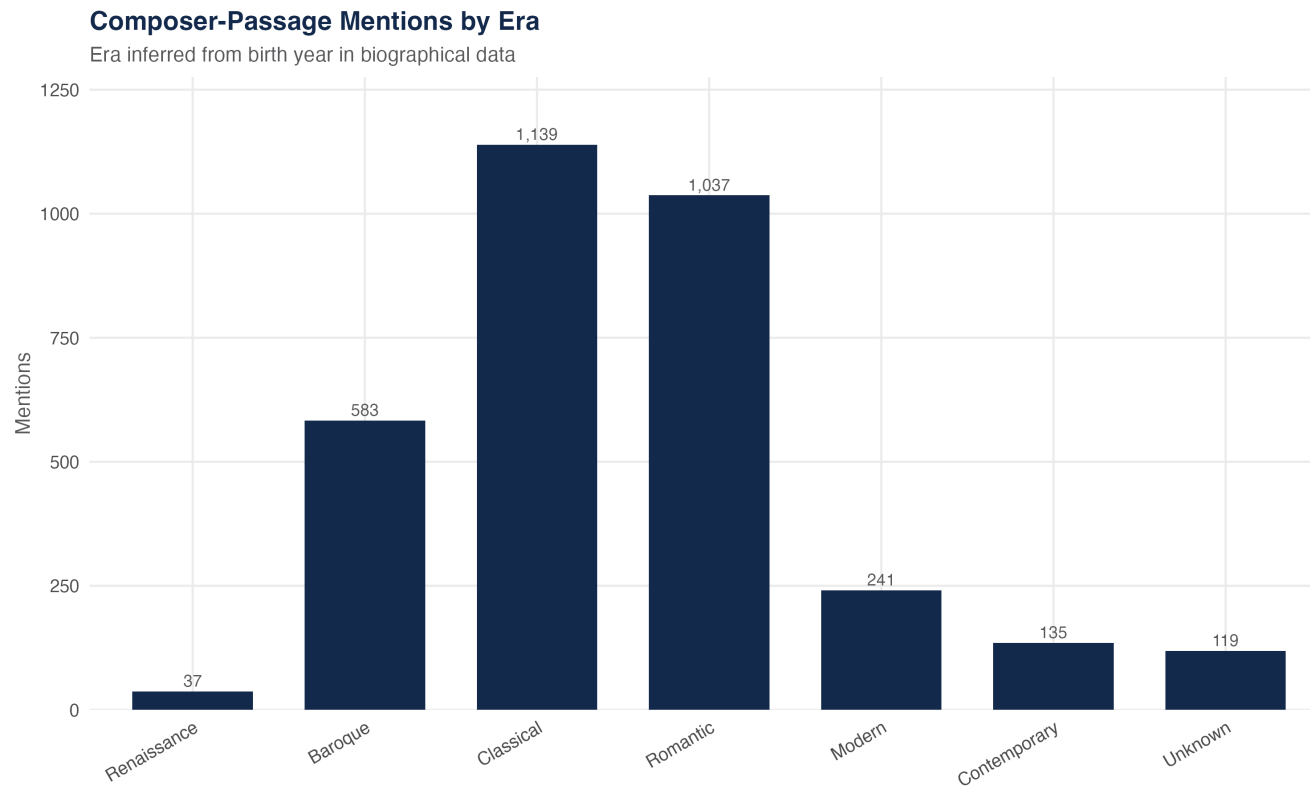


Figure 24: Total passage mentions by historical era (Baroque, Classical, Romantic, Modern, Contemporary, other).

9.2. Era by Gender

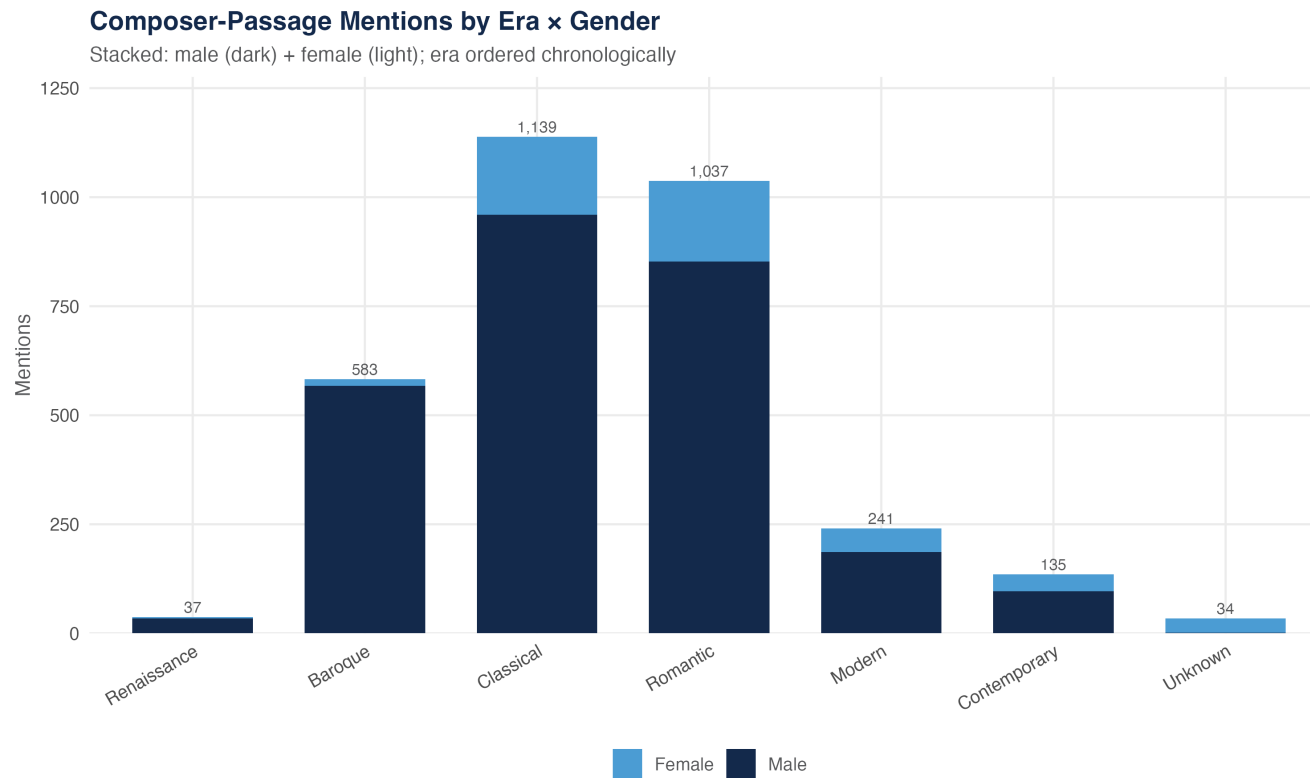


Figure 25: Passage mentions by era, split by gender. Reveals where in the historical timeline women composers' music appears.

9.3. Era: Percentage Breakdown by Demographic

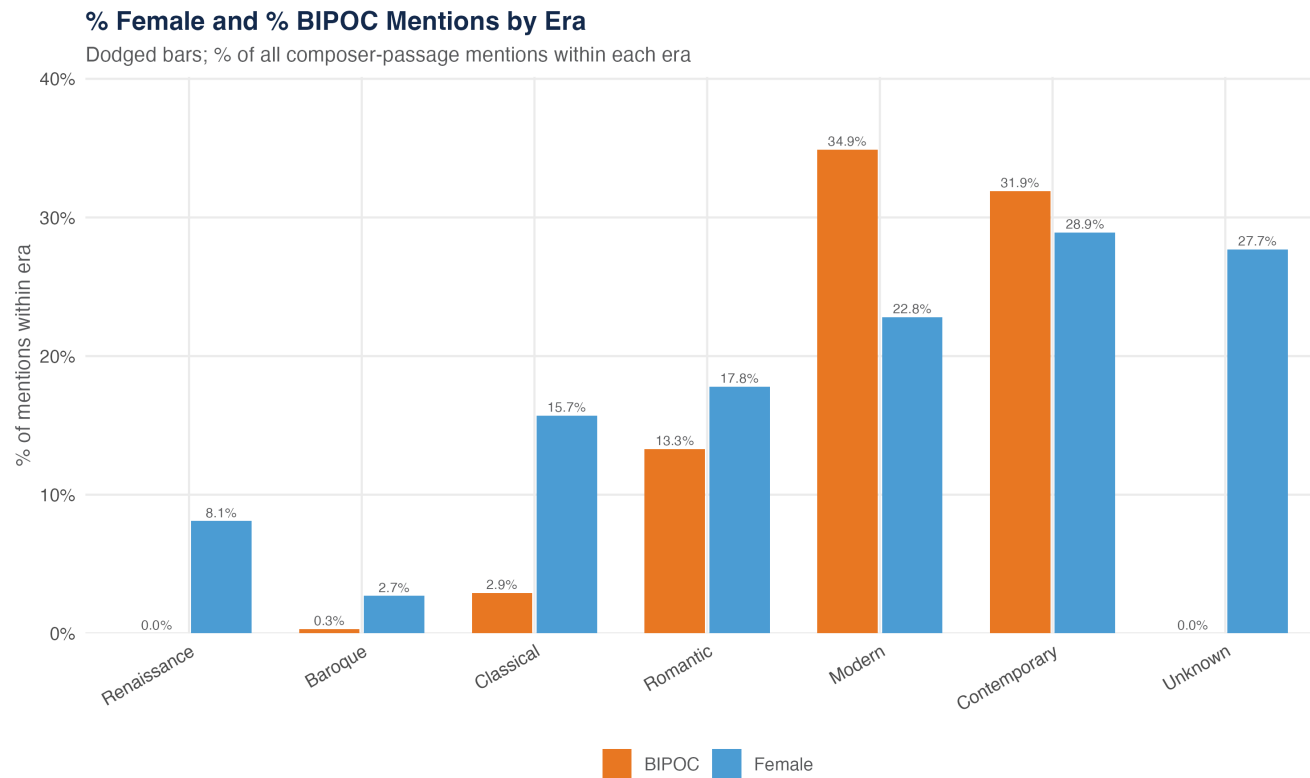


Figure 26: Proportional breakdown of passage mentions by era, showing BIPOC and female percentages within each historical period.

9.4. Era by Dominant / Marginalized Status

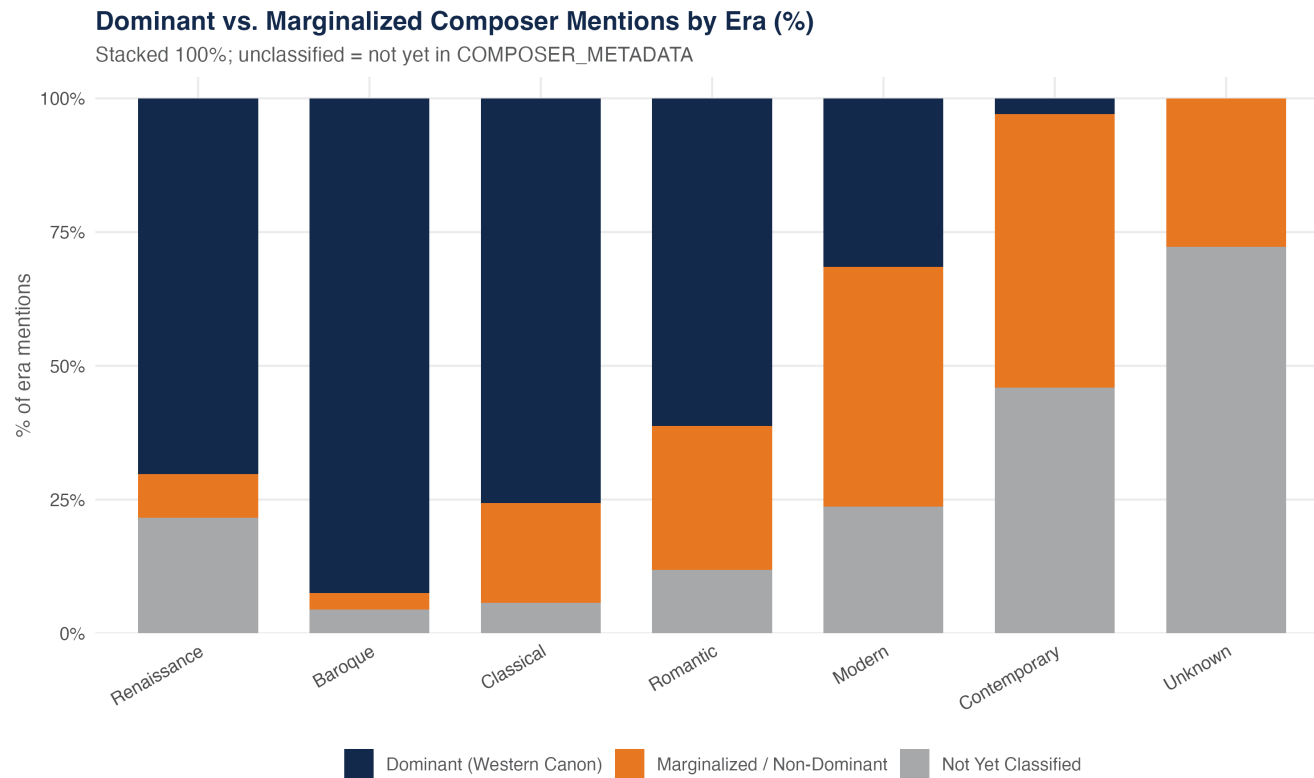


Figure 27: Passage mentions by era, showing stacked proportions of dominant, marginalized, and unclassified composers within each historical period.

10. Framing by Dominant vs. Marginalized Status

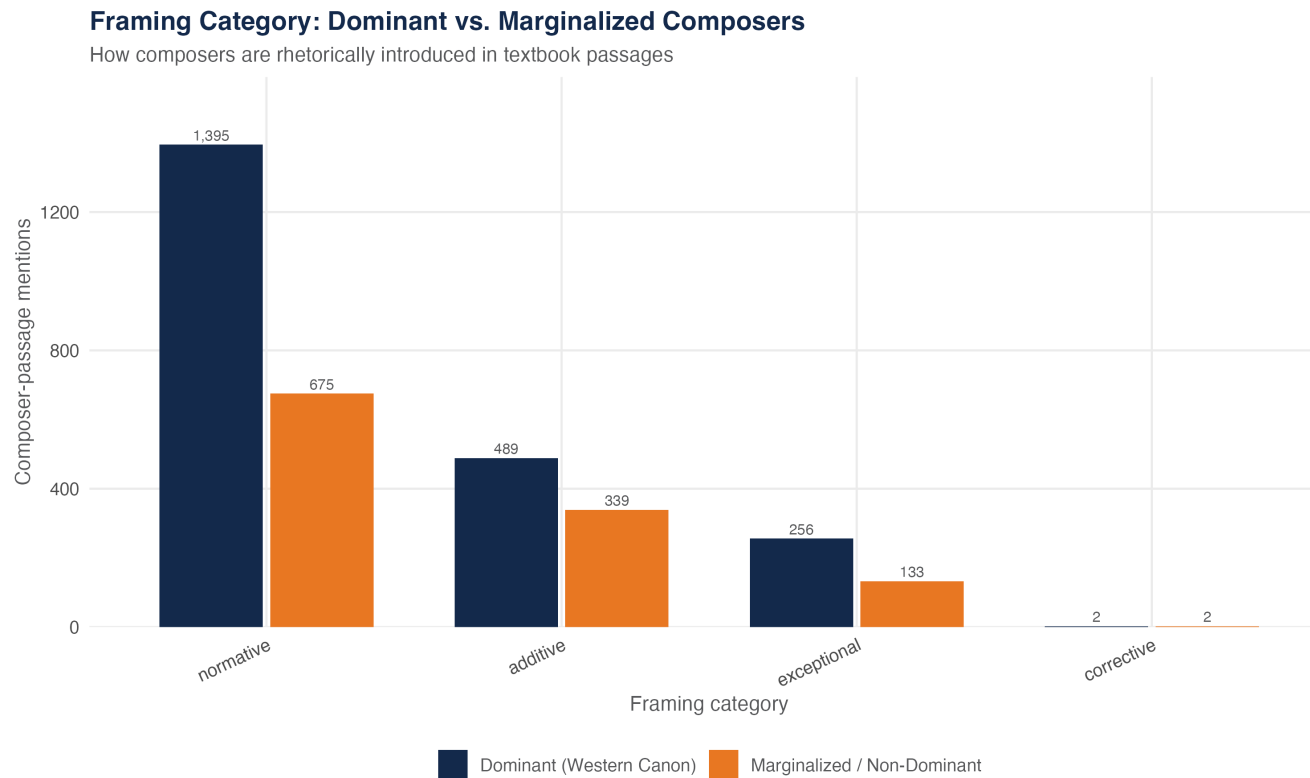


Figure 28: Framing category distribution for dominant vs. marginalized composers (mention counts and proportions).

Dominant composers are framed normatively in 64.6% of their mentions, marginalized composers in 57.6% – a 7-point normative deficit. The flip side is additive framing: marginalized composers appear in the “and also…” register in 30.2% of their mentions against 22.7% for dominant composers. A chi-square test of independence on the three substantive framing categories rejects the null of no association ($\chi^2 = 23.1$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$), and targeted Fisher’s exact tests localize the effect: dominant composers receive normative framing at greater odds ($OR = 1.34$, $p < .001$) and additive framing at lower odds ($OR = 0.68$, $p < .001$). Exceptional framing, by contrast, is statistically indistinguishable between the groups ($OR = 1.07$, $p = .62$). The effect is reliable but modest in magnitude (Cramér’s $V = 0.071$), and the corrective category (8 instances corpus-wide) is too sparse for inference.

Decomposing the marginalized group sharpens the picture: BIPOC composers show the largest normative deficit (53.3% vs. 64.6% dominant, an 11-point gap) and the highest additive rate in the corpus (35.4%). Women composers sit between the poles, with the corpus's highest exceptional rate (13.5%). Canonical White European male composers ground the theoretical argument while marginalized composers arrive after the fact to illustrate, supplement, or provide contrast.

Framing	Dominant	Marg.	BIPOC	Women
Normative	64.6%	57.6%	53.3%	58.6%
Additive	22.7%	30.2%	35.4%	27.7%
Exceptional	12.6%	11.9%	10.8%	13.5%
Corrective	0.1%	0.3%	0.5%	0.1%
<i>n</i> (mentions)	3,655	934	398	679

10.1. Framing Is Not Uniform Across Books

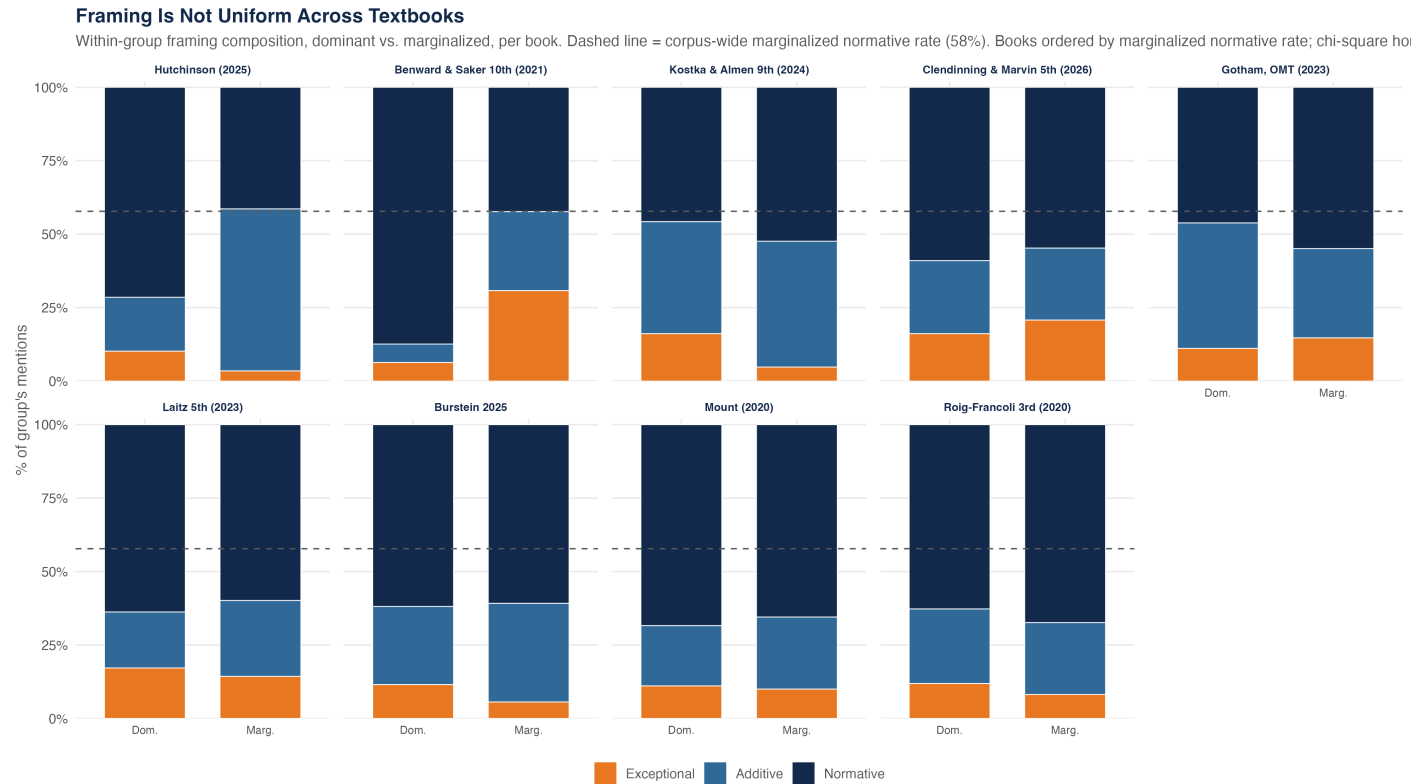


Figure 29: Within-group framing composition, dominant vs. marginalized, per textbook. Dashed line marks the corpus-wide marginalized normative rate (58%); books ordered by their marginalized normative rate. Books with fewer than 10 marginalized mentions omitted.

The corpus-level framing gap is an average, not a constant. Restricting to the nine textbooks with at least ten marginalized mentions, a chi-square test of homogeneity on the normative-versus-other split rejects a common rate ($\chi^2 = 17.9$, $df = 8$, $p = .022$). Marginalized composers are framed normatively in two-thirds of their appearances in Roig-Francolí (67.3%) and Mount (65.5%) but in fewer than half in Hutchinson (41.4%) and Benward & Saker (42.3%). Framing is not a fixed property of the discipline; it varies with editorial choices made book by book, which means it is also subject to editorial revision.

10.2. Within-Book Framing Gaps by Category

Within-Book Framing Gaps by Category

Each segment connects the dominant rate (blue) to the marginalized rate (amber) within a book. Longer segment = larger gap. Books with < 10 marginalized mentions omitted.



Figure 30: Within-book framing gaps. Each segment connects the dominant rate (blue) to the marginalized rate (amber) for one book; longer segments indicate larger gaps. Faceted by framing category; books ordered by additive gap.

The dumbbell view separates the two mechanisms of framing inequity. In the additive facet, nearly every segment points the same direction – marginalized rates exceed dominant rates – confirming that the supplementary register is systematically assigned to marginalized composers across the corpus rather than driven by one or two outliers. The normative facet mirrors this in reverse. The exceptional facet shows short segments scattered in both directions, consistent with the non-significant corpus-level exceptional contrast: no book systematically marks marginalized music as deviant more than its own dominant baseline, with Benward & Saker the visible exception.

11. Edition Deltas: What Changed Between Revisions

The table below tracks the change in BIPOC%, Female%, and BHMB% between successive editions of the same textbook (in percentage points, pp). $\Delta J'$ shows the corresponding change in overall Pielou evenness. Changes of ± 1 pp or less in BIPOC% and Female% are treated as negligible; changes of ± 5 pp or more are treated as meaningful.

Edition Pair	Years	Δ BIPOC pp	Δ Female pp	Δ BHMB pp	$\Delta J'$	Key change
Aldwell 4th $\rightarrow$ 5th	2011 $\rightarrow$ 2019	0.0	0.0	-5.0	+0.005	BHMB% drops 5 pp; no new BIPOC or female composers
Benward 8th $\rightarrow$ 10th	2008 $\rightarrow$ 2021	+0.0	-0.2	+1.0	-0.013	Negligible change across all metrics
Burstein 2nd $\rightarrow$ 3rd	2020 $\rightarrow$ 2024	+15.8	+23.7	-26.8	+0.202	Largest single-revision gain in corpus
Clendinning 3rd $\rightarrow$ 4th	2016 $\rightarrow$ 2021	+4.0	+7.8	-1.5	-0.004	Steady gains in both subgroups
Clendinning 4th $\rightarrow$ 5th	2021 $\rightarrow$ 2026	+10.2	-3.6	-4.5	+0.024	BIPOC continues rising; Female% dips slightly
Kostka 7th $\rightarrow$ 8th	2013 $\rightarrow$ 2018	+0.0	+0.1	+0.7	-0.005	Effectively unchanged across all dimensions
Kostka 8th $\rightarrow$ 9th	2018 $\rightarrow$ 2024	+2.1	+0.2	-1.2	+0.005	Marginal BIPOC gain; female essentially static
Laitz 2nd $\rightarrow$ 3rd	2008 $\rightarrow$ 2012	+0.2	+0.1	+1.2	-0.003	No meaningful change; BHMB% rises 1 pp
Laitz 3rd $\rightarrow$ 4th	2012 $\rightarrow$ 2016	0.0	0.0	-5.6	+0.037	BHMB% drops 6 pp; diversity unchanged
Laitz 4th $\rightarrow$ 5th	2016 $\rightarrow$ 2023	+23.5	+30.3	-16.7	+0.137	Major revision: BIPOC +24 pp, Female +30 pp

12. Structural Placement: Composer Centrality

Each passage in the corpus was assigned one of three structural roles using a combination of layout signals extracted from each textbook's visual and organisational cues:

- **Central** (primary analytical subject) – body text set at full-page width in the primary reading font, in sections whose titles introduce a new concept. Chapter-opening

and definitional passages were presumed Central.

- **Supplementary** (supporting example) – text in visually demarcated boxes, reduced font sizes, shaded panels, or with distinct margins; passages in sections explicitly labelled as supplementary reading, review, or further examples; and material in appendices or reference sections identified by page-numbering offsets or explicit appendix headers.
- **Application** (student exercise) – numbered or lettered prompt sequences, workbook pages, and sections explicitly labelled as exercises or drills. Figure captions were excluded from role scoring, as their rhetorical function is inherently subordinate to the surrounding analytical prose.

A passage's normalized within-chapter position (0 = chapter start, 1 = chapter end) served as a soft prior: passages in the opening third of a chapter were more likely to be scored Central; those in the final third, Application or Summary. The composite centrality score weights frequency of citation (40%), structural role (35%), and framing normativity (25%).

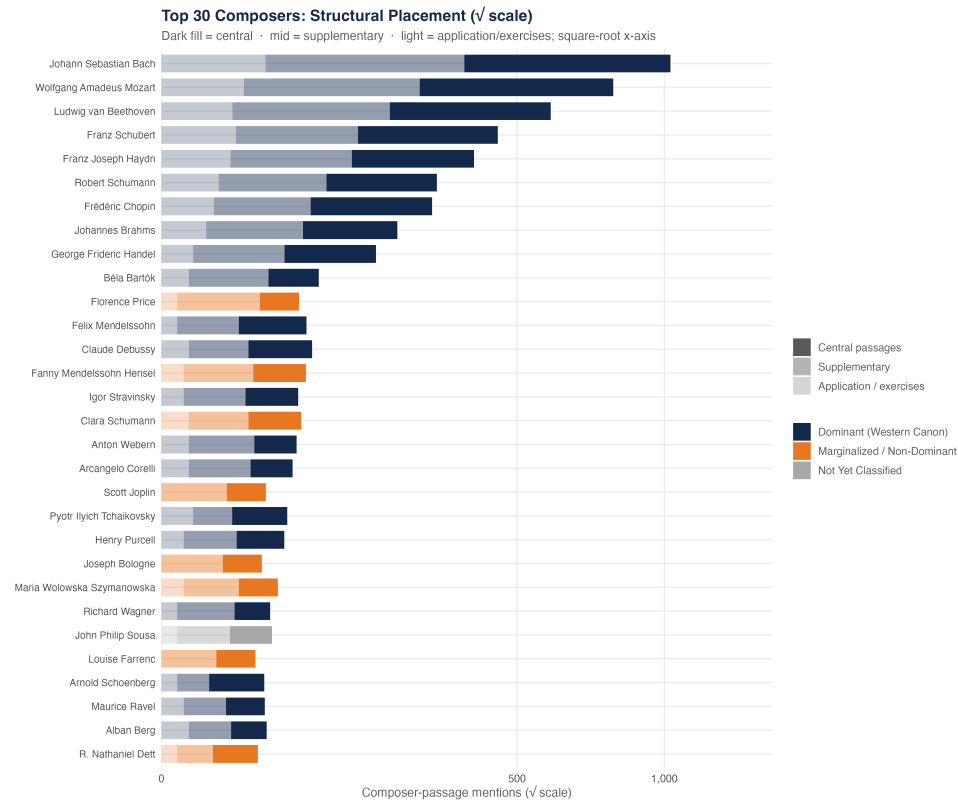


Figure 31: Structural placement scores for the top 30 composers by mention count. Bars colored by dominant (blue) vs. marginalized (amber). Centrality score = $0.40 \times \text{frequency} + 0.35 \times \text{placement} + 0.25 \times \text{framing normativity}$.

Structural placement measures not just how often a composer appears but *where* in the textbook's pedagogical architecture their music is deployed. Dominant composers appear in central passages in 47.1% of their mentions, compared with 43.7% for marginalized composers. The supplementary skew runs the other way: 52.8% of marginalized-composer mentions are supplementary, versus 41.0% for dominant composers. Application exercises – where students actively work with examples – show the sharpest disparity: marginalized composers receive only 3.5% application placement vs. 11.9% for dominant composers.

12.1. Placement by Gender and Race as Separate Axes

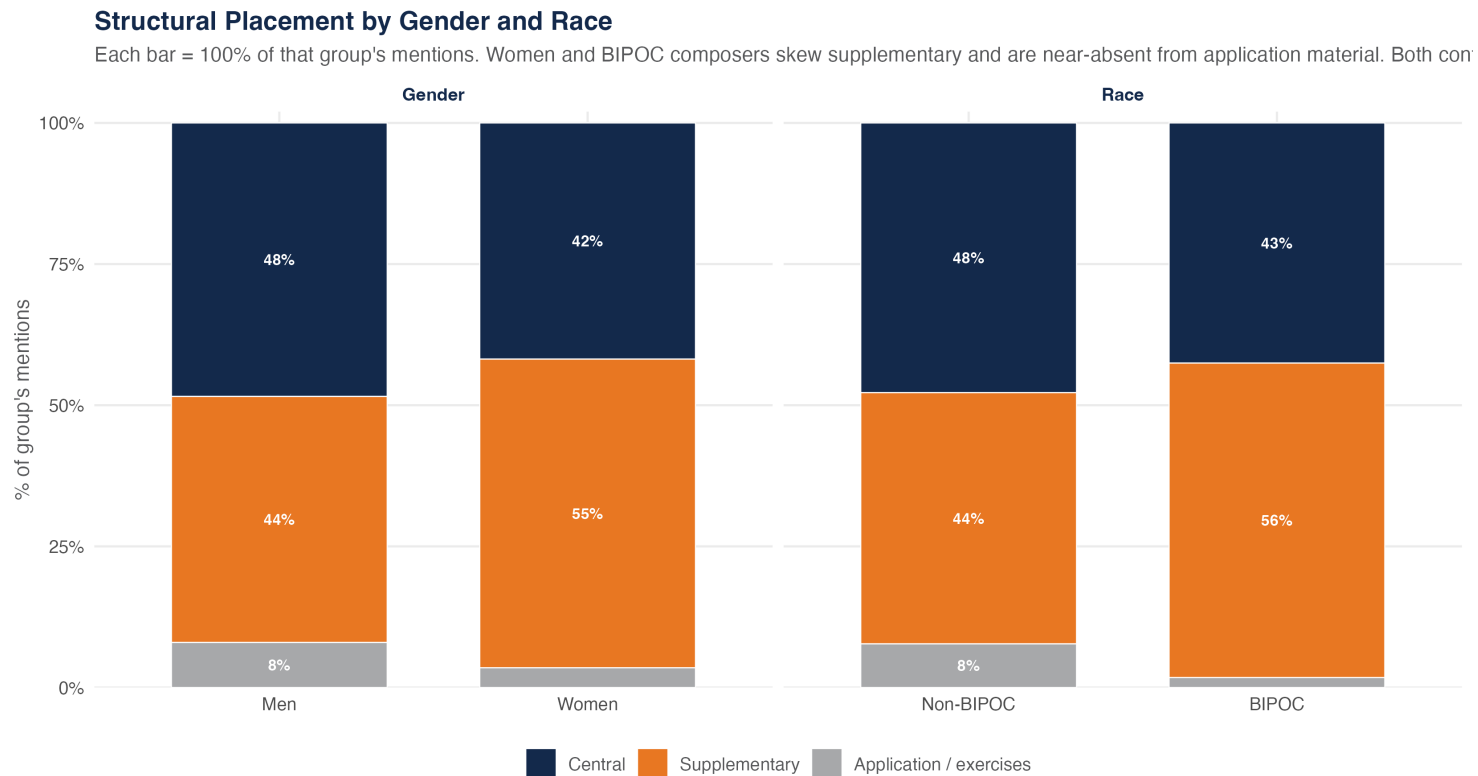


Figure 32: Structural placement by gender and by BIPOC status, analyzed as separate demographic axes. Each bar is 100% of that group's mentions, split by passage role.

The dominant / marginalized binary collapses two distinct demographic dimensions; decomposing it sharpens the placement asymmetry and shows it is not an artifact of the collapsed flag. Women composers appear in central passages less often than men (41.8% vs. 48.5%), skew supplementary (54.7% vs. 43.6%), and are underrepresented in application material (3.5% vs. 8.0%); the association between gender and structural role is highly reliable ($\chi^2 = 57.6$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$, Cramér's $V = 0.102$). BIPOC composers show the same supplementary skew (55.7% vs. 44.5%) and a near-total absence from exercises: 1.8% of BIPOC mentions occur in application material against 7.7% for non-BIPOC composers ($\chi^2 = 46.4$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$, $V = 0.091$). Both effect sizes exceed the framing effect ($V = 0.071$): where a composer's music is placed is more strongly patterned by demographics than how it is framed. The exercise-set finding is the starkest single number in this report – the music of BIPOC composers is almost never the material students are asked to work with directly, even where it is present in the prose.

13. Composer Co-occurrence Network

Composer Co-occurrence Network

Edges = 2 shared passages; node size = total mentions; color = dominant / marginalized / unclassified; layout = Fruchterman-Reingold

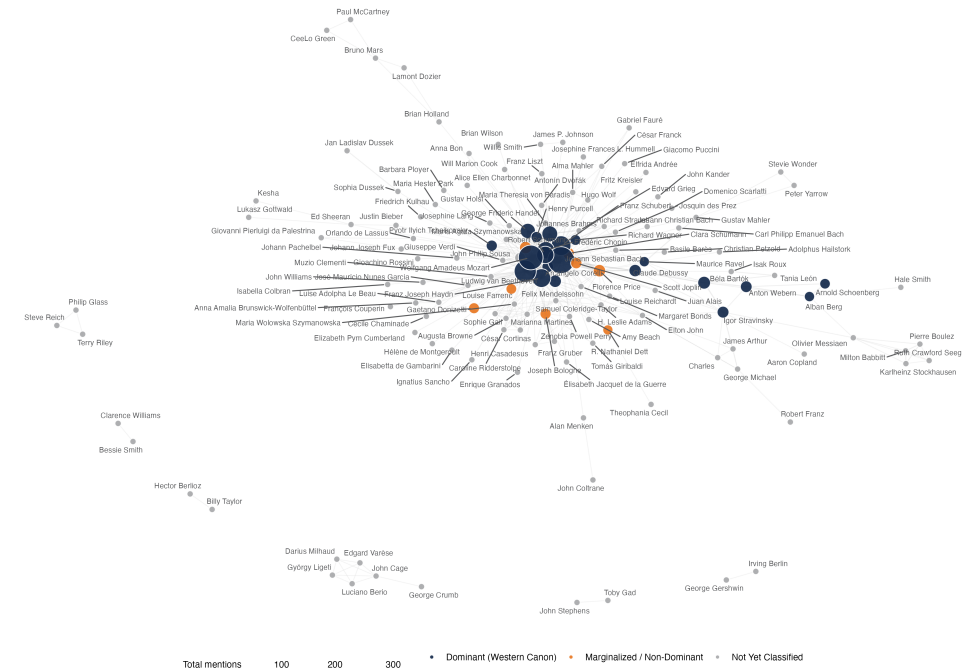


Figure 33: Co-occurrence network of composers appearing in the same passage or textbook section. Node size proportional to mention count; edge weight proportional to co-occurrence frequency. Color indicates dominant (blue) vs. marginalized (amber) status.

14. Chapter and Book Position

14.1. Within-Chapter Position by Textbook

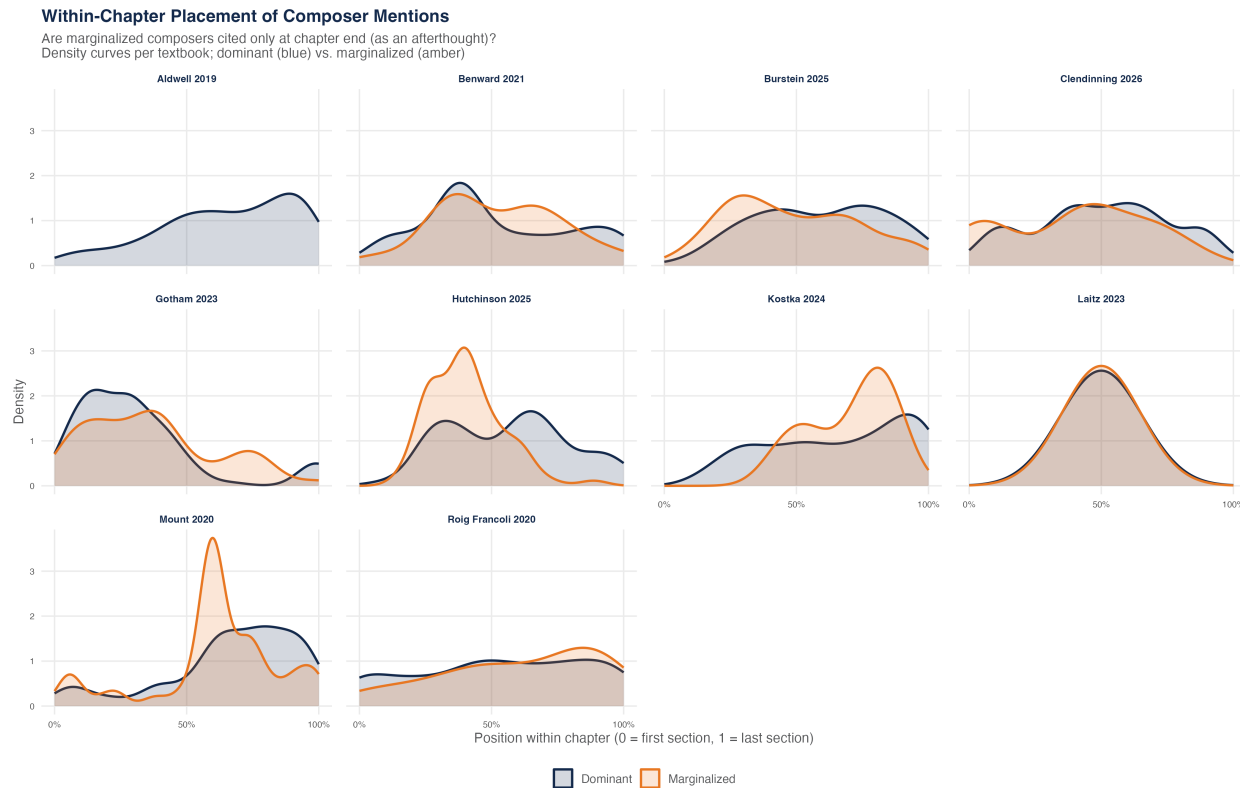


Figure 34: Within-chapter position (0 = chapter start, 1 = chapter end) of dominant, marginalized, and unclassified composer mentions, faceted by textbook. Density curves show where in a chapter's pedagogical arc diverse composers appear.

Dominant composers average a within-chapter position of 0.595 – past the midpoint, in the analytical body of the text where core theoretical concepts are developed. Marginalized composers average 0.501, essentially at the chapter midpoint. The gap is smaller than the placement and framing asymmetries documented above, and it should be read modestly: marginalized composers are not banished to chapter ends, but neither do they reach the later-chapter analytical depth at which dominant composers cluster. Faceting by textbook shows the pattern is relatively uniform across the corpus.

15. Passage Role by Musical Tradition

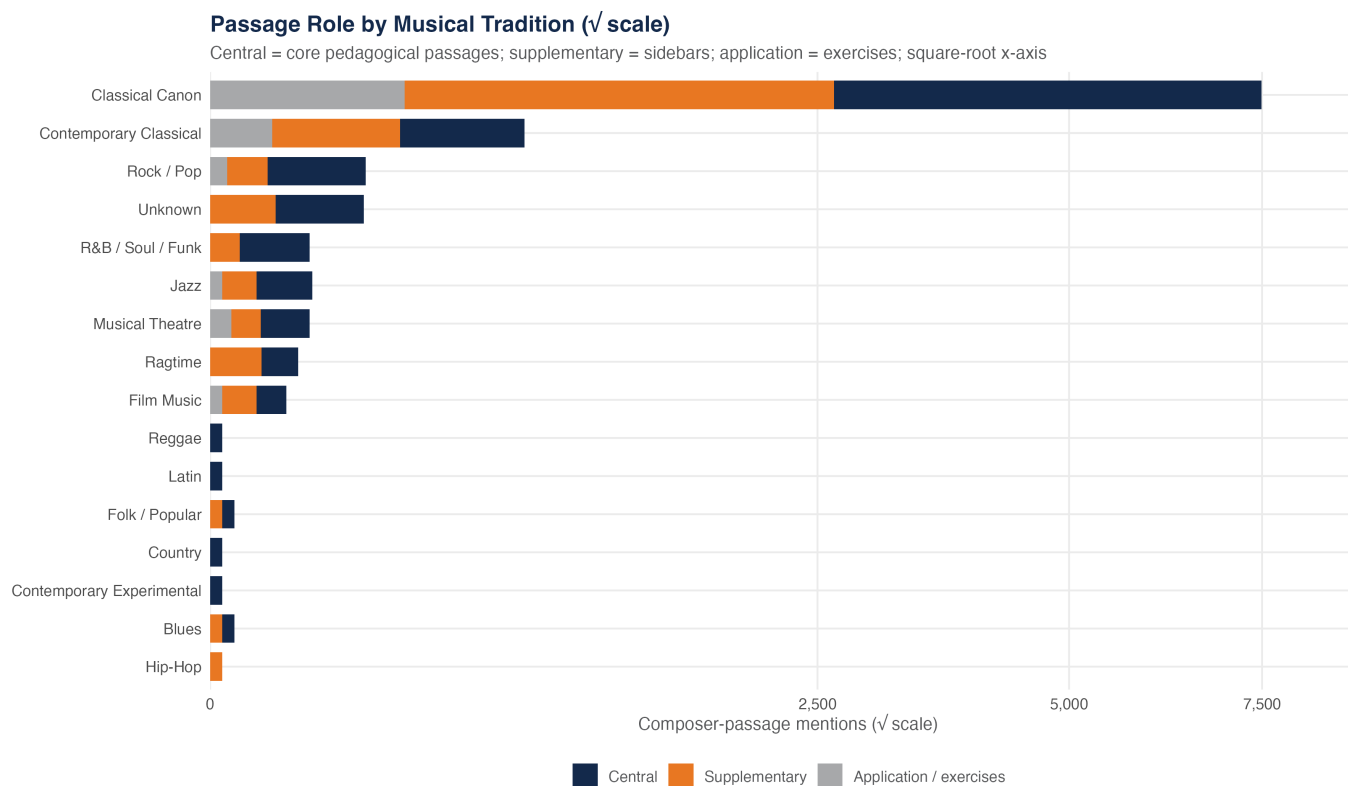


Figure 35: Passage role (core, supplementary, application) broken down by musical tradition. Shows whether non-Western and popular traditions appear in analytically central passages or are confined to supplementary and sidebar material.

16. Representation by Textbook

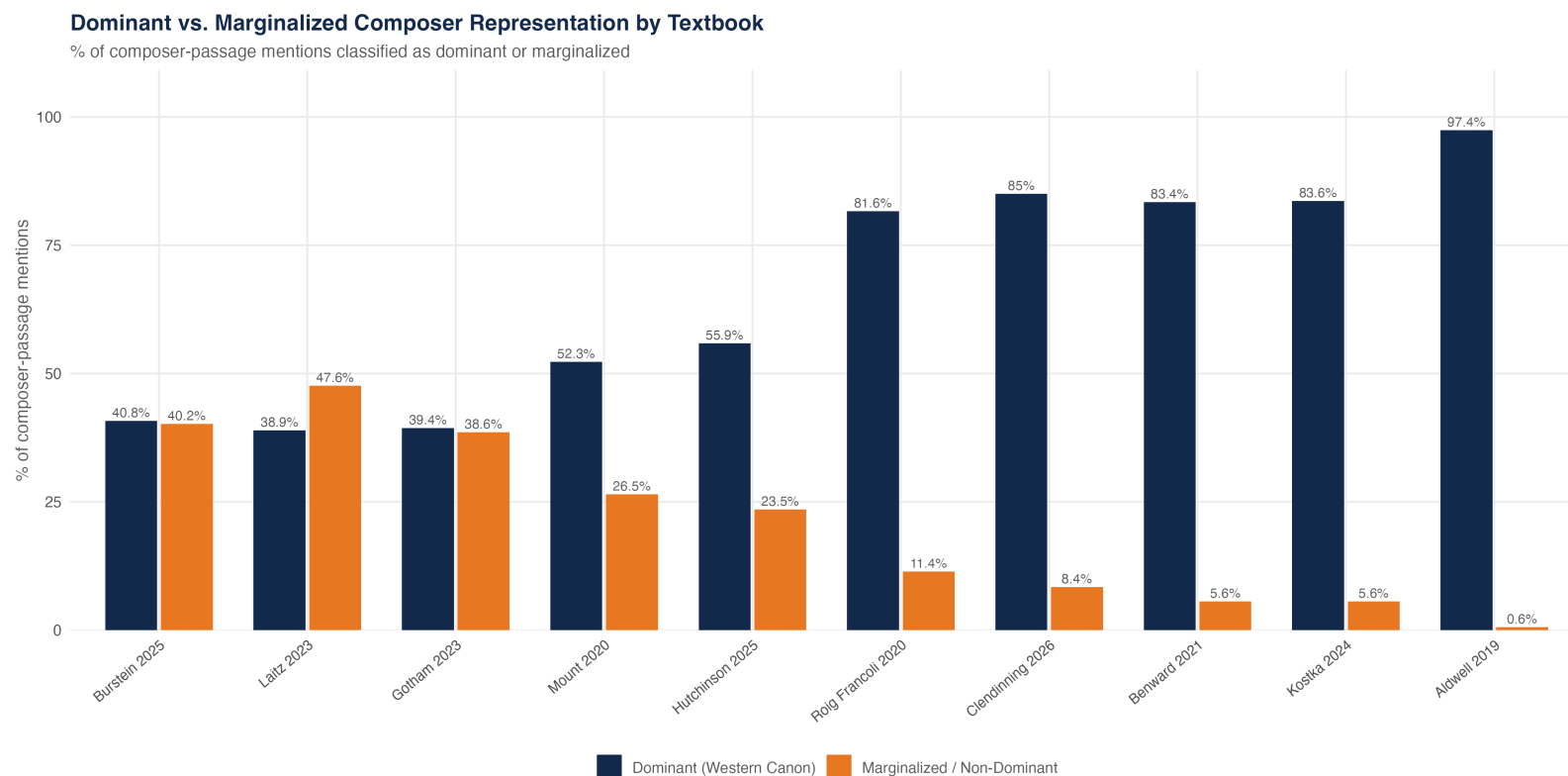


Figure 36: Dominant vs. marginalized composer percentage of total passage mentions, per textbook. Side-by-side bars with percentage labels.

Across the ten-book NLP corpus, 92 dominant composers account for 69.7% of all classified mentions while 242 marginalized composers together generate only 17.8%. The aggregate conceals real concentration: 32.0% of all marginalized-composer passages (164 of 512) are located in a single textbook (Laitz, 2023), and 73.6% of marginalized composers appear in only one of the ten textbooks. The two books with the broadest raw counts of diverse composers (Laitz and Gotham) have two of the lowest integration rates (39.6% and 12.8% respectively): breadth of representation is not the same as structural integration.

16.1. Breadth Is Not Integration

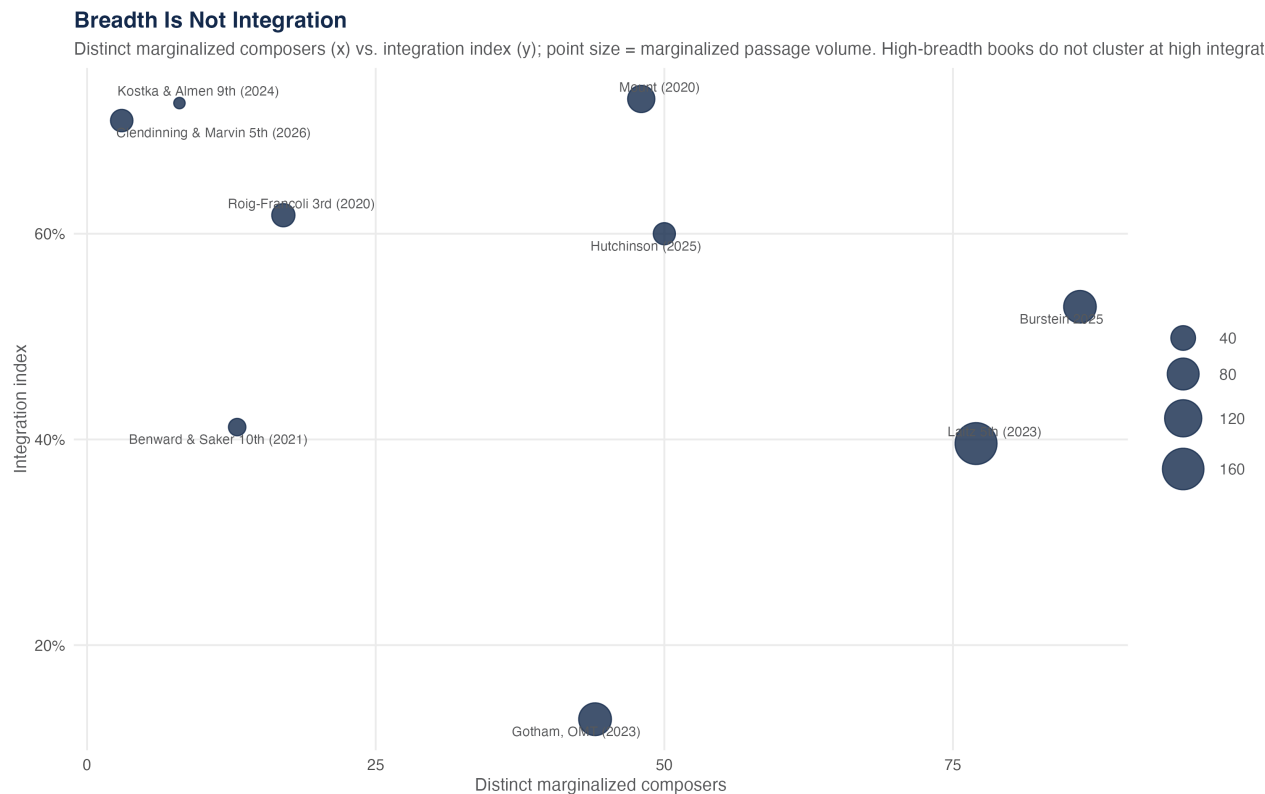


Figure 37: Distinct marginalized composers (breadth, x -axis) against the integration index (y -axis: share of marginalized passages that also cite a dominant composer); point size = marginalized passage volume. Aldwell ($n = 2$ passages) omitted as uninterpretable.

The integration index measures structural centrality rather than presence: for each book, the proportion of passages mentioning a marginalized composer that also mention a dominant one – marginalized music in shared analytic company rather than siloed in passages of its own. The scatter shows that breadth and integration are uncorrelated at best. Mount (73.1%) and Kostka & Almén (72.7%) top the integration ranking with modest rosters; Burstein & Straus carries the corpus's largest distinct-composer count (86) at a middling 52.9%; and the two highest-volume books, Laitz (39.6%) and Gotham (12.8%), sit at the bottom. Volume, breadth, and integration are three different quantities, and no book in the corpus maximizes all three.

17. Concept Associations: Dominant vs. Marginalized Passages

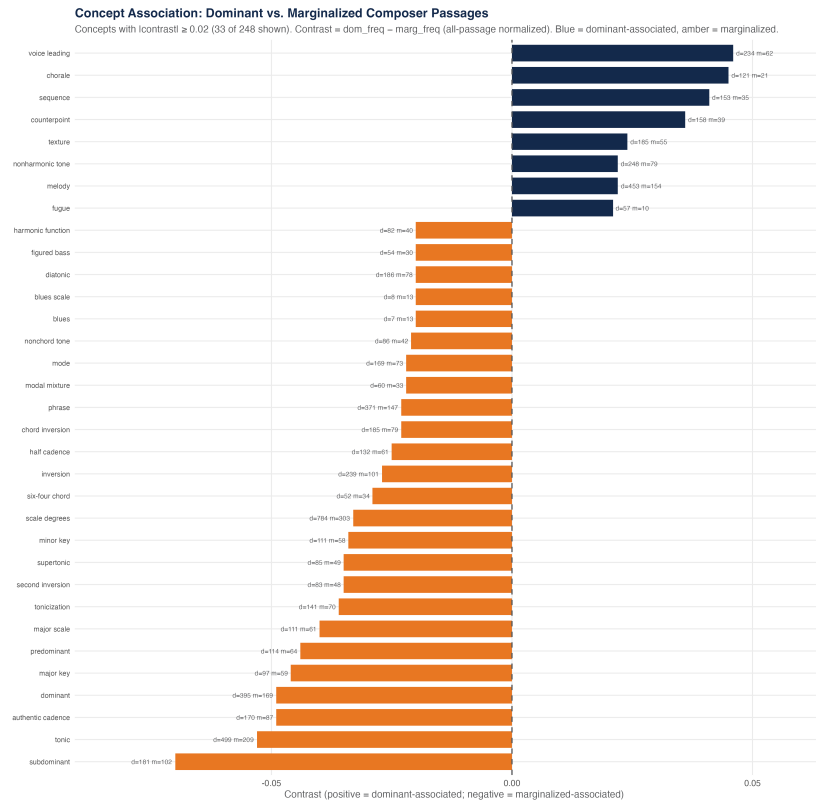


Figure 38: Contrast of theory-concept co-occurrence between dominant and marginalized composer passages. Concepts to the right appear disproportionately in marginalized-composer passages; those to the left are more prevalent in dominant-composer passages. Filtered to concepts with $|contrast| \geq 0.02$.

The vocabulary surrounding each group of passages tells a complementary story to the framing counts. Dominant-composer passages co-occur with the foundational technical apparatus of tonal theory – voice leading, harmonic progression, functional harmony.

18. Framing Gap by Textbook

18.1. Normative Framing Gap

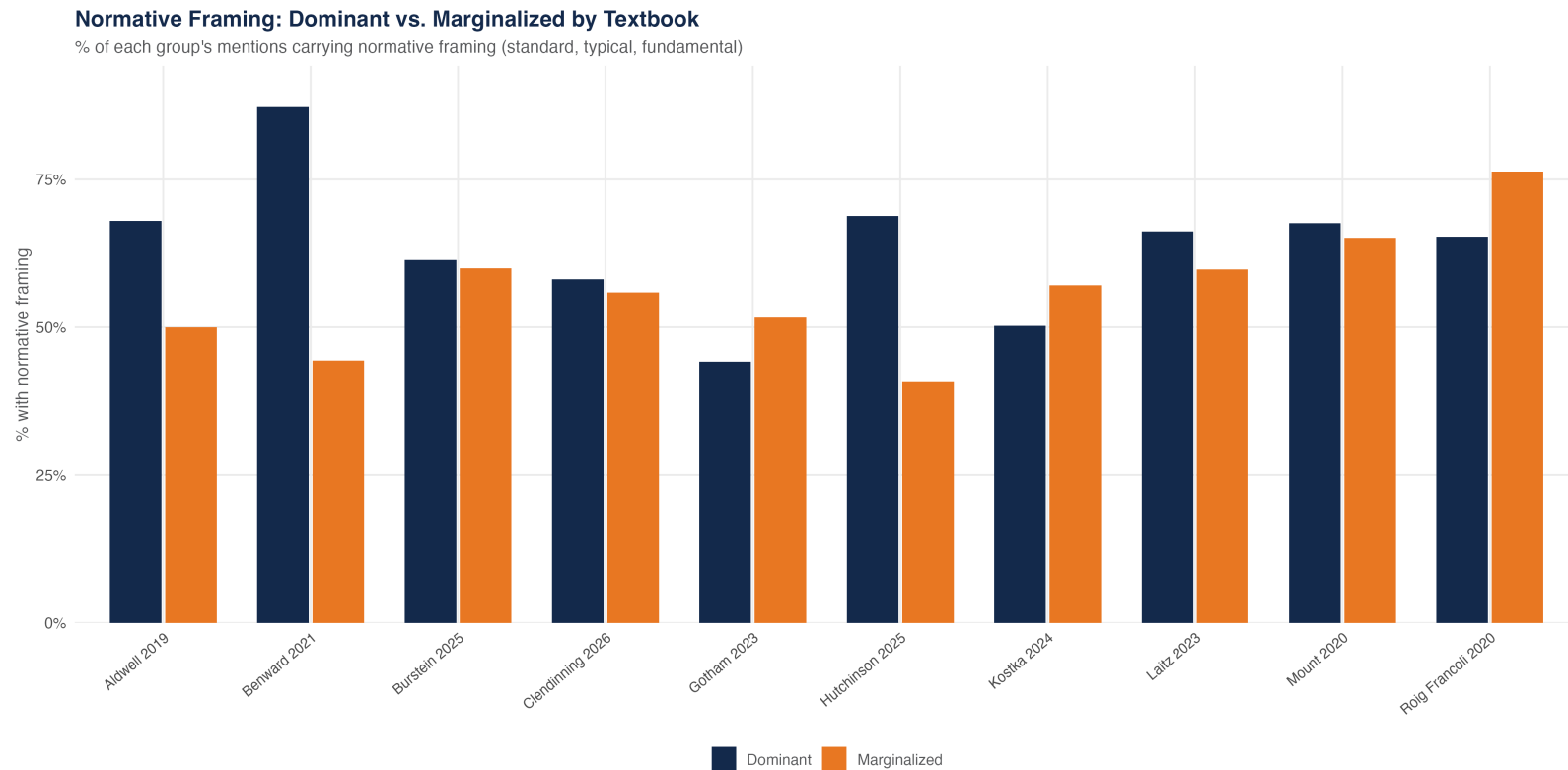


Figure 39: Normative framing gap per textbook shown through grouped bars for dominant and marginalized composers.

The framing gap plot makes the 7-point corpus-wide normative deficit legible at the individual textbook level, revealing which volumes drive the aggregate pattern and which approach parity. Notably, the two textbooks with the broadest raw counts of diverse representation (Laitz at 39.6% integration; Gotham at 12.8%) show that high volume of diverse composers does not translate directly into framing equity: a textbook can include many marginalized composers while continuing to frame them additively or exceptionally,

thereby reproducing the structural hierarchy through volume rather than resolving it.

18.2. Additive Framing Gap

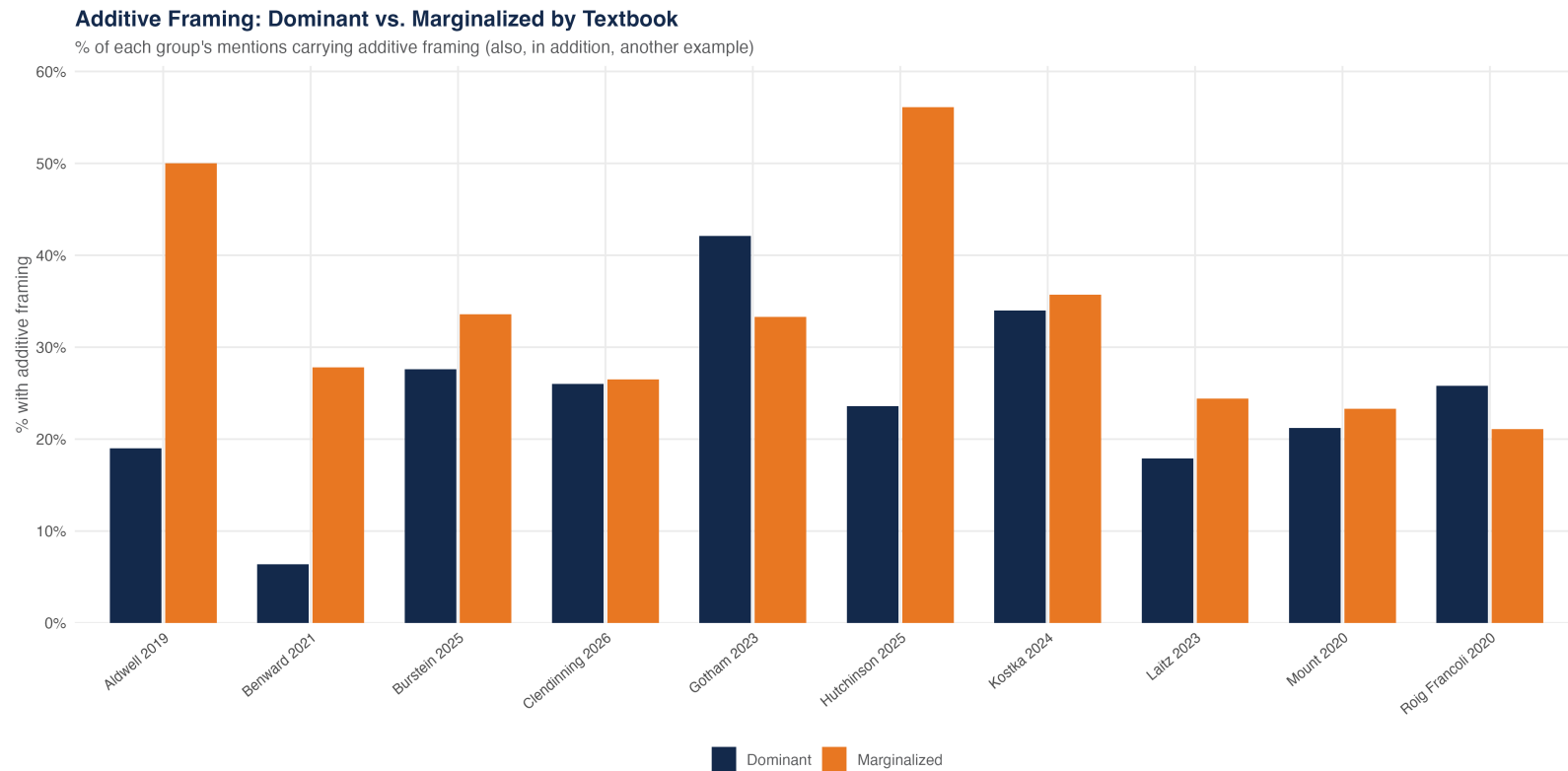


Figure 40: Additive framing gap per textbook shown through grouped bars for dominant and marginalized composers.

The additive gap is the mirror image of the normative gap. Where the normative gap identifies which books most strongly reserve concept-grounding status for dominant composers, the additive gap identifies which books most systematically assign the supplementary register to marginalized ones. Comparing the two plots reveals whether a book's framing inequity operates primarily by elevating dominant composers, by subordinating marginalized ones, or by both mechanisms simultaneously.

Summary of Key Findings

The table below synthesizes the principal quantitative findings from the NLP analysis. Where structural placement data are available only at the combined “marginalized” level, the Female and BIPOC columns share a single pooled figure (italicised). All headline group differences are statistically reliable: framing ($\chi^2 = 23.1$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$), placement by gender ($\chi^2 = 57.6$, $p < .001$) and by BIPOC status ($\chi^2 = 46.4$, $p < .001$), and between-book framing variation ($\chi^2 = 17.9$, $df = 8$, $p = .022$); the corrective category (8 instances corpus-wide) is too sparse for inference.

Dimension	Dominant	Female	BIPOC
Total mentions (NLP)	3,655 (69.7%)	679 (13.0%)	398 (7.6%)
Normative framing	64.6%	58.6%	53.3%
Additive framing	22.7%	27.7%	35.4%
Exceptional framing	12.6%	13.5%	10.8%
Corrective framing	0.1%	0.1%	0.5%
Central passages	47.1%	43.7% (combined marginalized)	
Supplementary passages	41.0%	52.8% (combined marginalized)	
Application passages	11.9%	3.5% (combined marginalized)	
Avg. chapter position	0.595	0.501 (combined marginalized)	

The evidence from the passage-level NLP analysis points to the structural conclusion that the Western classical canon – overwhelmingly White, European, and male – functions as the unmarked norm through which theoretical concepts are first introduced and generalized, while minority composers are selectively inserted as supplements, variants, or curiosities. Their presence is real but structurally subordinate: they illustrate the system built on others’ music rather than grounding it. The data show that this subordination operates simultaneously at multiple levels – quantity, structural placement, framing language, and vocabulary – in ways that persist even in the most recently revised editions, and even in the textbooks with the highest raw counts of diverse representation. Breadth of inclusion is not the same as structural integration, and the gap between the two is precisely what Ewell’s critique demands we confront.

Key Sources

Ewell, Philip A. “Music Theory and the White Racial Frame.” Plenary presentation at the 42nd Annual Meeting of the Society for Music Theory, Columbus, OH, November 2019.

Ewell, Philip A. “Music Theory and the White Racial Frame.” *Music Theory Online* 26, no. 2 (2020). doi : 10.30535/mt0.26.2.4.

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